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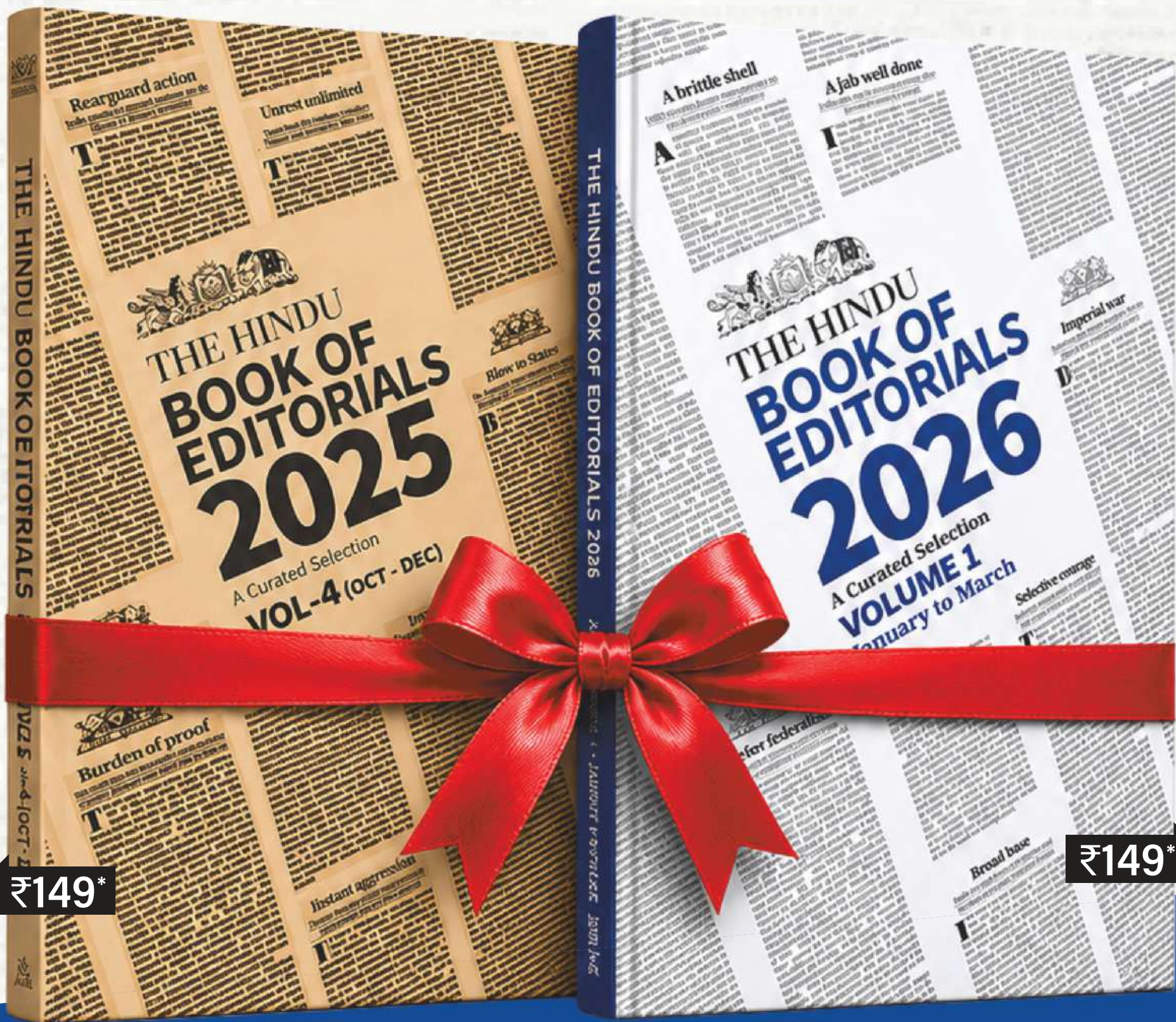


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IN BRIEF

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NewsClick hails Delhi HC verdict to quash FIR

NEW DELHI
Digital news platform NewsClick on Thursday said the Delhi High Court's decision to quash an FIR registered against it has vindicated its long-held position that the case was an "attack on press freedom". » **Page 2**

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Trump backs off from Iran strikes, signals deal is likely

Tehran has 'approved' talks, says the U.S. President while announcing pause on attacks hours after threatening to hit Iran 'very hard', seize Kharg Island; Hormuz blockade to 'remain till deal finalised'

Stanly Johny

After two days of tit-for-tat strikes with Iran, U.S. President Donald Trump on Thursday said he would pause further attacks, just hours after threatening to hit the country "very hard" and seize Kharg Island and its energy infrastructure. He claimed that Tehran had "approved" talks.

"Based on the fact that discussions with the Islamic Republic of Iran have been brought to the highest level of Iranian leadership and approved, I have, as President of the United States of America, cancelled the scheduled strikes and bombings against Iran this evening," Mr. Trump wrote in a social media post on Thursday night. "Discussions and final points have been, in



A screengrab from a video released by the U.S. CENTCOM on Thursday shows strikes targeting 'Iranian infrastructure'. AFP

both concept and great detail, approved by all parties involved, including the United States, Israel, Saudi Arabia, UAE, Qatar, Turkey, Pakistan, Bahrain, Kuwait, Jordan, Egypt, and others," he said adding that the U.S. naval blockade of Iranian ports "will remain in full force and effect until this transaction is finalised – Time and place of the

signing to be announced shortly."

Earlier in the day, Mr. Trump had written in another post that he would continue striking Iran after both sides exchanged fire for two consecutive nights. After Thursday's attack, Iran also announced that it closed the Strait of Hormuz to all traffic.

In recent months, Mr.

Trump had made several U-turns after making harsh threats against Iran and issuing ultimatums, often claiming progress in talks.

After Mr. Trump threatened to take Kharg Island, Mohammad-Bagher Ghalibaf, Iran's Parliament Speaker, had warned that any further escalation would lead to an explosion of energy infrastructure and markets. "Wrong strategies and impulsive decisions will reset the entire board for the worse, explode energy infrastructure and markets and create an endless quagmire that you will be stuck in for years. You will see a different Iran," he wrote in a social media post.

CONTINUED ON
» **PAGE 12**
RELATED REPORTS ON
» **PAGE 16**

U.S. hits one more vessel with Indian crew off Oman

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI/NEW DELHI

The U.S. on Thursday attacked a bitumen carrier, *Jalveer*, with 20 Indian seafarers aboard off Oman, marking the third such incident in four days. The crew was reported safe.

India had already lodged a strong protest with the U.S. after strikes on tankers *Marivex* and *Settebello* carrying Indian crew, in which three Indians aboard *Settebello* were killed.

The U.S. military said *Jalveer* was targeted for allegedly transporting Iranian oil. India described the incidents as deeply concerning. Political parties, including Congress and CPI(M), condemned the strikes and urged stronger government action and accountability

FULL REPORT ON
» **PAGE 14**

SC: homemakers build nation, work worth at least ₹30,000 a month

Rizmi Lia M.
CHENNAI

Observing that homemakers deserve to be recognised as "nation builders", the Supreme Court on Thursday ruled that the unpaid domestic work performed by them must be monetised at a minimum of ₹30,000 per month while calculating compensation for deaths in road accidents.

The ruling came in an appeal arising from a motor accident claim in Punjab where a woman named Reshma died in a road accident in November 2001. Her husband and three children approached the Motor Accident Claims Tribunal seeking compensation. While the tribunal awarded compensation in 2003, they approached the High Court to enhance the amount. On appeal, the High Court enhanced the compensation to ₹8.43

The ruling came in an appeal arising from a motor accident claim

lakh with 7.5% interest, providing for a higher rate of interest in case of delay in payment.

A Division Bench of Justice Sanjay Karol and Justice N.K. Singh said the contribution of a homemaker extended beyond the household and played a vital role in nation-building. "We are of the view that the housewife contributes to the growth of the human being and the nation," said the Bench.

Justice Karol stated that "loss of domestic care" would be an additional ground to the heads of damages previously recognised by the court.

CONTINUED ON
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 **MARUTI SUZUKI**

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'AIIMS syringes were recalled as as precaution for patient safety'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The recall of certain batches of disposable syringes at the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), New Delhi, was undertaken as a “precautionary measure” in the interest of patient safety, a source in the Union Health Ministry said on Thursday. The action followed reports flagged by the user department over quality-related

issues, the source added. The Centre’s clarification comes after a report in *The Hindu* highlighted concerns raised by Rajya Sabha member Haris Beeran over repeated recalls and their possible implications.

RS member’s letter
In a letter to Union Health Minister J.P. Nadda on Wednesday, Mr. Beeran had said two recall notices had been issued in a span of three weeks for 10 ml

syringes supplied by different manufacturers. The source said the batches were withdrawn immediately after complaints and the supplier has been directed to replace the affected batch. “The action was taken to ensure that any potential deficiency in medical consumables is identified and addressed at the earliest. Further action will follow as per rules,” the source added.

Delhi to formulate tighter norms for coaching centres

Multidisciplinary committee to frame rules on building compliances, fee structure and student safety; panel set up in the aftermath of Old Rajender Nagar tragedy identified systemic gaps: Sood

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood on Thursday said the government will soon set up a committee to draft a regulatory framework for coaching institutes in the national capital, addressing issues such as student safety, fee structure and infrastructural standards.

The announcement comes following judicial and administrative reviews after the Old Rajender Nagar coaching centre tragedy of 2024, in which three civil services aspirants drowned in the basement of a coaching centre due to flooding and alleged structural and infrastructure deficiencies.

Last month, at least five students were killed and several others were injured when a multi-storey commercial building in the Saidulajab area near Saket metro station collapsed. The structure housed coaching institutes and cafes and offices, and construction work was under way on the uppermost floor at the time of the collapse.



In 2024, three civil services aspirants drowned in the basement of a coaching centre (left) due to flooding and ‘structural and infrastructure’ deficiencies; at least five students were killed after a commercial building near Saket metro station collapsed last month. FILE PHOTO

According to a statement from the Minister’s office, the decision was taken at a high-level meeting on Thursday attended by senior officials from regulatory and civic agencies, including the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, Delhi Fire Services, Directorate of Higher Education, Delhi Police, Department of Labour, Department of Health and Urban Development Department.

The framework is intended to facilitate the shift from a “fragmented civic monitoring towards a coor-

ordinated academic and regulatory framework” for coaching institutes, according to the government. A multidisciplinary team will be constituted to formulate guidelines, which will cover areas such as fee structure, student safety and welfare, mental health support and counselling mechanism, infrastructure standards and building safety compliances, fire and emergency preparedness measures, teacher and staff welfare, and standardised working conditions. “Establishment of grie-

vance redressal mechanisms for coaching staff and students will also be looked after by the committee. Periodic inspections and compliance monitoring will strictly be followed,” the statement read.

The Delhi government has designated the Director of Higher Education as the nodal officer for drafting the policy.

‘Rigorous review’
The Minister’s office said the incident at a coaching institute in Old Rajender Nagar, which resulted in the loss of lives, necessitated a “rigorous judicial and administrative review”. “To ensure that such a tragedy is never repeated, the Hon’ble Delhi High Court constituted a high-level committee under the chairmanship of Justice (Retd.) R.K. Gauba to examine the vulnerabilities of coaching hubs and recommend comprehensive preventive measures. The Gauba Committee has since submitted its report, identified systemic gaps and proposed a framework for stricter regulation and oversight,” the statement added.

Shifting of slums near PM house: MCD to ensure school for all children

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) will admit in schools every child from families being relocated from slum clusters near the Prime Minister’s residence in the Race Course area, irrespective of whether they have the required documents, officials said on Thursday.

“Under the National Education Policy, the MCD admits every child up to Class 5. It does not matter whether a child has the required documentation or not; we will ensure that every child is enrolled in school,” said the civic body’s Education Committee Chairman, Yogesh Verma. His remarks came after the Delhi High Court directed that children of families relocated from the three slum clusters near the Prime Minister’s residence be admitted to nearby government or MCD schools in their respective classes and that admission deadlines be extended, if necessary.

The court order was passed on June 4 while hearing appeals by residents challenging their relocation to flats at Savda Ghevra in north-west Delhi.

NewsClick hails HC verdict, calls FIR against it an ‘attack on press freedom’

Shrimansi Kaushik
NEW DELHI

Digital news platform NewsClick on Thursday said the Delhi High Court’s decision to quash an FIR registered against it and its founder and Editor-in-Chief Prabir Purkayastha has vindicated its long-held position that the case was an “attack on press freedom”.

“NewsClick’s only fault has been to practise journalism that covers people’s movements,” the organisation said in a statement.

The Delhi High Court quashed the FIR registered by Delhi Police’s Economic Offences Wing and proceedings initiated by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) against NewsClick and Mr. Purkayastha, holding that allegations relating to foreign direct investment (FDI), share valuation and expenditure of funds did not disclose offences of cheating or criminal breach of trust.

According to NewsClick, the court noted that the ED proceedings were “not only *mala fide*, but also an arbitrary attack and abuse of powers on the free and impartial journalism of the



Journalist bodies and activists have welcomed the quashing of FIR against NewsClick founder Prabir Purkayastha (centre). FILE PHOTO

petitioners”. “Apart from bald assertions of there being a criminal conspiracy, there was not a whisper of any incriminating allegation... the continuation of the FIR was nothing but a gross abuse of the process of law,” the statement quoted from the judgment. NewsClick said the verdict had reaffirmed its faith in the judiciary and expressed confidence that other proceedings against it will also be resolved.

‘Misuse of law’
The May 29 judgment has been welcomed by journalist bodies, civil society groups and legal experts, many of whom have called

corruption activist Anjali Bhardwaj said the judgment “exposed the politicisation” of agencies such as the ED, which are expected to function independently. Senior Supreme Court lawyer Colin Gonsalves described the judgment as “historic” and “hard-hitting”.

‘Concocted allegations’
Senior Communist Party of India (Marxist) leader Brinda Karat termed the ruling “significant”, saying the case had sought to silence an important dissenting voice in the media. “This goes beyond individual case. The allegations were concocted and manufactured. It requires a lot of courage to report on events that show the misuse of power,” she said.

Delhi University professor and public intellectual Apoorvanand said the nature of the raids and probe suggested an attempt to cripple NewsClick as a media organisation. “How do you recover the losses of the employees who lost their jobs?” he said.

SEE ALSO
» PAGE 12

Special team formed to clean up Yamuna, restore river flow: CM

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday said a special coordination team comprising Delhi and its neighbouring States has begun work on restoring the Yamuna’s uninterrupted flow and tackling pollution.

She made the remarks after attending the 11th meeting of the Governing Council of NITI Aayog, chaired by the Prime Minister, where she presented her vision for the deve-

lopment of the national capital and its role in achieving the goal of developed India by 2047.

“Rising above political differences, the team has already begun working in a planned manner to restore the Yamuna river’s uninterrupted flow and address the serious problem of pollution,” the Chief Minister’s Office (CMO) said in a statement. Ms. Gupta also said Delhi is building road infrastructure worth ₹1 lakh crore with support from the Centre, read the CMO statement.

June 30 target set for completing rainwater harvesting work: L-G

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Lieutenant-Governor (L-G) Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Thursday directed all civic agencies to make rainwater harvesting systems fully operational before the monsoon and set June 30 as the deadline to complete desilting, repair and maintenance works across the Capital.

At a review meeting on monsoon preparedness, Mr. Sandhu asked agencies to assess the total water storage and recharge ca-

capacity of existing rainwater harvesting systems in Delhi. According to officials, the Delhi Development Authority, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi and the New Delhi Municipal Council were instructed to complete pending structural repairs, cleaning of pits and chambers, and maintenance of rooftop pipes before June. Mr. Sandhu said the city needed a clear assessment of the installed capacity of rainwater harvesting structures to help future planning and water conservation efforts.

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LEGAL NOTICE

BEFORE THE MOTOR ACCIDENTS CLAIMS TRIBUNAL & SPECIAL SUB JUDGE (MOTOR TRIBUNAL), THANJAVUR
MCOP No.1382225
Thannarasu Vs. Petitioner
Akash Singh, No. 186, 2nd Floor, GTV Nagar, Hoskothahalli Nagar, North-East Delhi, Delhi - 110 009 3rd respondent
NOTICE
Please take notice that in the above case the petitioners took several steps to serve Court Notice on 3rd respondent through Court and Post for his appearance in Court. But this Court Notice could not be served on 3rd respondent. so, this Court ordered the 3rd respondent to appear before the above Court in person (or) by pleader on 30.06.2026 at 10.30 a.m. to answer all material questions relating to this case. In default of appearance on the hearing date the issues will be decided by the Court ex parte.
N.EIamparuthi, B.A., B.L., Advocate, Thanjavur.

LEGAL NOTICE

IN THE COURT OF XXX ADDL. CITY CIVIL & SESSIONS JUDGE AT BANGALORE CITY (CCH No. 31)
O.S. No. 7819/2025
Plaintiff : Mithuna Constructions Pvt. Ltd., No. 1342, Skanda Towers, 5th Floor, MCEHS Layout, Dr. Shivram Karanth Nagar, Jakkur Post, Bengaluru-64, Represented by Managing Director, Hanumantha
Vs
Defendants : M/s. Catena Homes India Pvt. Ltd. & another
Summons to Defendant No. 1, By Way of U/o. 5 R 20 of CPC
M/s Catena Homes India Pvt. Ltd. Office address: B-1399, Shrilal Pradhan Complex, Sangam Vihar, TIGRI T-Point New Delhi-110080 By it's Chief Operating officer (CEO)
...1st Defendant
Where as the above named plaintiff instituted a suit against you and others for ejectment from schedule property and for recovery of arrears of rent of Rs. 2,52,525-00 with costs and interest. You are here by summoned to appear before the XXth Addl City Civil Court Bangalore (CCH. No. 31) on 13th day July 2026 at 11.00 am in person or through advocate / pleader to answer the questions to the same. Failing which the suit will be heard and determined as ex parte.
SCHEDULE
Property bearing Flat No. 002-A, Ground Floor, A Block, Mithuna White Aspera, Apartment, Srirampura, Jakkur, Bengaluru-64, comprising of one hall, one kitchen, one pooja room, three bedrooms, three toilets, two balcony and one car park situated in the apartment, along with all fittings and fixture including electrical and sanitary fittings, kitchen cabinets and bedroom wardrobes which are one door bell, 5 ceiling fans, 14 CFL lights, one geyser, 3 exhaust fans, 3 inbuilt wardrobes without mirror, one wall mounted mirror big, inbuilt TV cabinet, Modular kitchen with chimney one, one queen size bed without mattress, single bed without mattress, bed side table three, wash mirrors three.
Given Under my hand seal of this hon'ble court on this 08th day of June 2026.
By order of the Court, Senior Sheristadar, City Civil Court, Bangalore.
ADVOCATE FOR PETITIONER : Sri. Viswanath Sabarad, Advocates No. 147/19, 48th Cross, 3rd Block, Rajajinagar, Bangalore-10.

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LEGAL NOTICE

IN THE COURT OF XXX ADDL. CITY CIVIL & SESSIONS JUDGE AT BANGALORE CITY (CCH No. 31)
O.S. No. 7818/2025
Plaintiff : Sri. Sachin .H.R., S/o, H.B. Ramachandrappa, aged about 30 years, No. 123/1, Manju Krupa, Near Durgambika Temple, Nittuvalli, Davanagere-577004.
Vs
Defendants : M/s. Catena Homes India Pvt. Ltd. & another
Summons to Defendant No. 1, By Way of U/o. 5 R 20 of CPC
M/s Catena Homes India Pvt. Ltd. Office address: B-1399, Shrilal Pradhan Complex, Sangam Vihar, TIGRI T-Point New Delhi-110080 By it's Chief Operating officer (CEO)
...1st Defendant
Where as the above named plaintiff instituted a suit against you and others for ejectment from schedule property and for recovery of arrears of rent of Rs. 2,52,525-00 with costs and interest. You are here by summoned to appear before the XXth Addl City Civil Court Bangalore (CCH. No. 31) on 13th day July 2026 at 11.00 am in person or through advocate / pleader to answer the questions to the same. Failing which the suit will be heard and determined as ex parte.
SCHEDULE
Property bearing Flat A-319, 3rd Floor, A-Block, Mithuna White Bells, Venkateshwara Layout, Jakkur, Bengaluru-64, comprising of one hall, one kitchen, three bedrooms, three washrooms, one balcony and one car park situated in the apartment, along with all fittings and fixture including electrical and sanitary fittings, kitchen cabinets and bedroom wardrobes which are one door bell, sixty LED Bulb, 5 calling bells, two shoe rack, one wall mounted TV cabinet, one pooja unit, three inbuilt wardrobes without mirror in bedrooms, wall mounted three mirrors, one crockery unit three queen size cot, two bed side table and one modular kitchen chimney.
Given Under my hand seal of this hon'ble court on this 08th day of June 2026.
By order of the Court, Senior Sheristadar, City Civil Court, Bangalore.
ADVOCATE FOR PETITIONER : Sri. Viswanath Sabarad, Advocates No. 147/19, 48th Cross, 3rd Block, Rajajinagar, Bangalore-10.

IN THE COURT OF XXX ADDL. CITY CIVIL & SESSIONS JUDGE AT BANGALORE CITY (CCH No. 31)
O.S. No. 7817/2025
Plaintiff : Sri Kenchappa Krishnamurthy, S/o, Kenchappa, aged about 71 years, R/o, Nidhi Disha Nilaya, Near Banni Mara Temple, 3rd Cross, Yangammana Katte, Sahyadri Nagara, Chitradurga-577501.
Vs
Defendants : M/s. Catena Homes India Pvt. Ltd. & another
Summons to Defendant No. 1, By Way of U/o. 5 R 20 of CPC
M/s Catena Homes India Pvt. Ltd. Office address: B-1399, Shrilal Pradhan Complex, Sangam Vihar, TIGRI T-Point New Delhi-110080 By it's Chief Operating officer (CEO)
...1st Defendant
Where as the above named plaintiff instituted a suit against you and others for ejectment from schedule property and for recovery of arrears of rent of Rs. 2,52,525-00 with costs and interest. You are here by summoned to appear before the XXth Addl City Civil Court Bangalore (CCH. No. 31) on 13th day July 2026 at 11.00 am in person or through advocate / pleader to answer the questions to the same. Failing which the suit will be heard and determined as ex parte.
SCHEDULE
Property bearing Flat No. 316, 3rd Floor, A-Block, Mithuna White Bells, Venkateshwara Layout, Jakkur, Bengaluru-64, comprising of one hall, one kitchen, three bedrooms, three washrooms, one balcony and one car park situated in the apartment, along with all fittings and fixture including electrical and sanitary fittings, kitchen cabinets and bedroom wardrobes which are one door bell, sixty LED Bulb, 5 calling bells, two shoe rack, one wall mounted TV cabinet, one pooja unit, three inbuilt wardrobes without mirror in bedrooms, wall mounted three mirrors, one crockery unit three queen size cot, two bed side table and one modular kitchen chimney.
Given Under my hand seal of this hon'ble court on this 08th day of June 2026.
By order of the Court, Senior Sheristadar, City Civil Court, Bangalore.
ADVOCATE FOR PETITIONER : Sri. Viswanath Sabarad, Advocates No. 147/19, 48th Cross, 3rd Block, Rajajinagar, Bangalore-10.

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Sukhu, Mann seek ‘fair’ share for their States from Centre

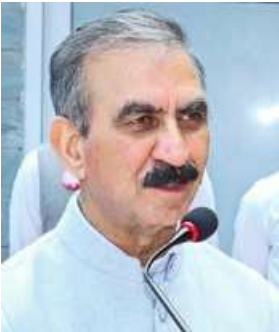
At NITI Aayog Governing Council meeting, Himachal CM urges PM to set up a panel to evaluate financial impact on the State; Punjab CM demands special status on the lines of N-E States, J&K

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

Himachal Pradesh Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu and Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Thursday urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to set up a high-level committee to evaluate the financial impact on the hill State and accord Special Category Status (SCS) to the western border State respectively.

They were speaking at the 11th Governing Council meeting of NITI Aayog held under the theme ‘Inclusive human development for Viksit Bharat’, chaired by the Prime Minister in New Delhi.

Key concerns
Mr. Sukhu said the financial impact arose from several key concerns, including the discontinuation of the Revenue Deficit Grant (RDG, i.e. statutory financial transfers provided by the Centre to specific States to bridge the gap between their assessed revenue and expenditure), losses caused by natural disasters, inadequate compensation



Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu and (right) Bhagwant Mann. FILE PHOTOS

from hydropower projects in terms of free power and revenue shortfalls resulting from the Goods and Services Tax framework.

He said Himachal is contributing towards the growth of the country despite these limitations and sought a detailed report by a high-level committee to the Government of India so that the State may get its “due share”.

‘Major blow’
“The discontinuation of RDG posed a major blow to the economy of the State and the ₹25,000 crore provided to the State is insufficient to compensate the loss. It should be increased to ₹50,000 crore so that development activities can be



carried out in a smooth manner,” he said.

“Himachal Pradesh provides ₹90,000 crore ecological services to the country as per a study conducted by the Indian Institute of Forest Management. However, the State is not being compensated accordingly against its contribution towards preserving ecology. The State was being deprived of fair amount of free power on 13,000 MW power being produced in the State. The State has still not received arrears amounting to ₹7,000 crore from the Bhakra Beas Management Board. It bore the brunt of natural disasters and still awaits the announced ₹1,500 crore special assistance,” Mr. Sukhu

added.

90:10 funding: Mann
Mr. Mann sought a special package for the revitalisation of border areas and demanded that Punjab be accorded SCS with 90:10 funding under all Centrally-sponsored schemes on the lines of hill States, north-eastern States and Jammu & Kashmir.

“Punjab is a frontline State sharing a 553-km border with Pakistan. It faces a deep and multidimensional crisis that includes persistent cross-border terrorism, drone-based smuggling of heroin and weapons. This has resulted in a drug addiction epidemic among youth, organised crime and daily hardship for farmers cultivating land between the security fence and the International Border under Border Security Force escort,” he said.

“Although Punjab acts as a buffer for the country against repeated hostilities from our neighbour, support from the Government of India has been grossly inadequate for the State and its border areas,” Mr. Mann added.

Set up anti-conversion cells: U.P. Governor to all colleges in State

Press Trust of India
LUCKNOW

Uttar Pradesh Governor and Chancellor of State universities Anandiben Patel has directed all medical, dental and other higher educational institutions in the State to establish dedicated cells preventing alleged religious conversions through “inducement or mental pressure”, officials said on Thursday.

The directive followed reports of alleged conversion-related incidents linked to King George’s Medical University and Sanjay Gandhi Postgraduate Institute of Medical Sciences in Lucknow. Subsequently, Atal Bihari Vajpayee Medical University has asked all its affiliated colleges to implement the directions on priority.

In a letter issued by the Governor’s Secretariat on May 28, institutions were asked to ensure a “safe, secular and academic environ-



Anandiben Patel. FILE PHOTO

ment” and remain vigilant against such activities. The letter stated that educational institutions are “not only centres of knowledge and innovation but also the foundation for the moral, intellectual and social development of youth”, and campuses should remain places of “academic excellence, intellectual freedom and harmony”.

The Governor’s office directed institutions to activate anti-radicalisation cells, strengthen counselling mechanisms, monitor hostels and sensitive areas, and prevent entry of unauthorised outsiders.

Shah vows to remove AFSPA from almost all N-E States next year

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday said the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act, or AFSPA, will be withdrawn from the entire Northeast (N-E) next year, barring one or two States.



Amit Shah in New Delhi on Thursday. ANI

Speaking at the signing of a tripartite Memorandum of Understanding between the Centre, Assam and Nagaland to facilitate mineral oil operations in the Assam-Nagaland boundary areas, he said shrinking of areas covered under AFSPA is an indicator of peace. “I am confident that barring one or two States, we will withdraw AFSPA from the entire Northeast next year,” he said.

Underlining that the signing of the MoU was a “historic moment”, Mr. Shah said it has removed the last hurdle in Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s vision of a developed Northeast.

Oil exploration activities remained stalled for more than three decades in the disputed area belt along the Assam-Nagaland border due to jurisdictional differences.

“This will open new avenues for mineral exploration in the Northeast. The area not only has oil and gas but huge mineral deposits, which could not be explored due to law and order issues,” he said.

With just one MoU, the extraction capacity of 1,000-1,500 barrels per day can be increased by 10 times, Mr. Shah said.

‘Increased capacity’
“In one field alone, there are possibilities of recovery of more than ₹15,000 crore. If we extract the oil deposits spread across Nagaland, we would be able to reduce dependence on foreign countries for our oil needs,” he said.

Mr. Shah added that since Mr. Modi took charge, he kept his focus on the Northeast and became the PM with the highest number of visits to the region. Since 2019, 12 accords have been signed between various groups and State governments, resulting in a drop of around 80% in incidents of violence in the region, he said. “The development of both Assam and Nagaland remained hampered for a long time because a consensus could not be reached for an MoU. It is the best example of cooperative federalism,” he said.

5,123 Gujarat govt. workers booked for traffic offences

The Hindu Bureau
AHMEDABAD

Gujarat Director General of Police G.S. Malik said the police fined as many as 5,123 government officials and employees for violating helmet regulations and recovered fines amounting to ₹16.58 lakh during a month-long Statewide special enforcement drive aimed at improving road safety and reducing fatalities among two-wheeler riders.

The numbers include over 1.88 lakh violators and a total of ₹5.21 crore fines recovered.

“Our commitment is to save lives. Riders and pillion passengers should wear helmets, and motorists should use seat belts. The objective is not to collect fines, but to save lives,” he said.

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THE HINDU
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Taking cognisance of the cab aggregators' 'arm-twisting' tactics for forcibly extracting tips from customers, Maharashtra Transport Minister Pratap Sarnaik on Thursday directed the Transport Commissioner to take action against erring taxi companies. He also announced that a new aggregator policy for the sector will be introduced soon. "The Minister has taken immediate cognizance of the demand raised by Kalyan Lok Sabha MP Shrikant Eknath Shinde regarding incidents involving app-based taxis. These incidents include drivers compelling passengers to pay additional amounts," an official said.

Bhojpur superstar Pawan Singh, Bihar Health Minister Nishant Kumar and BJP national media co-in-charge Sanjay Mayukh were among nine candidates who on Thursday were declared elected unopposed to the State Legislative Council. Altogether eight candidates of the ruling NDA and one of the Opposition RJD had filed their nomination papers for nine seats of the Upper House, to which biennial elections were recently announced. They all were handed over respective certificates of election after the time was up for withdrawal of nomination papers, said an official of the Vidhan Sabha Secretariat. PTI

Mohammed Iqbal
JAIPUR



Equal representation

With the unopposed election of three candidates, Rajasthan has now an equal representation of five Rajya Sabha MPs each from the ruling BJP and the Opposition Congress. The State has a total of 10 Rajya Sabha seats.

Press Trust of India
SHIMLA

Family members of sailor Aditya Sharma, 23, who was killed in a U.S. strike on an oil tanker near Strait of Hormuz, on Thursday urged the Himachal government and the Centre to get his body back to his native Hamirpur so that last rites could be performed.

Aditya was among the three crew members who were killed after the U.S. military struck Palau-flagged *MT Settebello* in the Gulf of Oman on June 10, accusing it of violating an American blockade by attempting to transport oil from Iran. There were 24 Indian crewmen on board the vessel, of whom 21 were rescued.

Aditya, a deck cadet on probation, was the only son



ward. We demand an inquiry." Aditya's uncle Sanjiv said they spent several anxious hours trying to ascertain his whereabouts after receiving information that he was missing.

Aditya was planning to visit home in May, but decided to extend his stay at the vessel for a month, he added.

"We are trying to get the

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

During the hearing, the High Court granted Mr. Abhishek interim protection for three weeks and directed the CID not to take



TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee arriving at the headquarters of the West Bengal police to appear before the CID, in Kolkata on Thursday. PTI

The Diamond Harbour MP had moved the court seeking protection from coercive action by the CID over its probe into the alleged forgery of party

According to the CID, Mr. Abhishek had sent a written communication to

The signature row had sparked a rebellion in the TMC, with 58 of its MLAs forming a bloc and electing Mr. Ritabrata as the Leader of the Opposition.

The Hindu Bureau
COIMBATORE

He said the TVK had emerged as a new democratic force, winning 108 constituencies in the 2026 Assembly election. The CPI decided to extend external support to the TVK government to back the verdict of



CPI Tamil Nadu secretary
M. Veerapandian

the people as a political duty, he said.

As for the upcoming by-elections, he said that when the situation arose, the party would decide its stand. "We want to protect secularism. There is no private enmity with the BJP. The BJP and the RSS are the only forces we oppose politically. We will work with any party that joins us to protect the welfare of the workers and the State," he said.

Stand welcomed

Mr. Veerapandian said the CPI welcomed the TVK government's stand on the Thirupparankundram issue and the two-language policy. "The TVK government needs time, but should implement its electoral promises. However, it cannot take time to ensure law and order," he said.

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Ms. Devi, 59, is among the oldest members of the BJP in Manipur and has

In Mizoram, K. Laltluangkima of the ruling Zoram People's Movement is pitted against lawyer-writer Zothansangi Hmar of the Mizo National Front. The election will be held on June 18.

The Hindu Bureau
GURUGRAM

DEEO Bijender Hooda, however, told *The Hindu* over the phone that she had violated the conduct rules for government employees by leaving her sta-



CJP demonstration at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on June 6 calling for resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan. ANI

“They have not assigned any reason. It makes me believe I have been suspended because I took part in the Cockroach Janta Par-

ty protest,” she said.

Ms. Dalal said her 21-year-old son failed to make it to the final list of Delhi head constable exam despite “working hard” and alleged the exam was leaked.

“The NEET exam got the media spotlight, but there was little talk about the head constable exam leak,” she said, adding that her family had “no political background for generations”.

The Hindu Bureau
GURUGRAM

Gurugram Mayor Raj Rani told *The Hindu* that charges listed under 'garbage collection' will be called 'sanitation charge'. She said the revised head will cover all sanitation and cleaning work by the corporation, including road sweeping and sewage pipeline cleaning. The nomenclature will be updated on the MCG website, she said.

However, Sushant Lok II and II Residents' Welfare Association (RWA) presi-

Bills issued by the MCG over the past few months have included automated garbage collection charges ranging from ₹200 to ₹600. RWAs argue that the MCG does not provide re-

Gaurav Singla, a resident of Sector 43, said his property tax bill included the garbage collection fee despite the corporation not providing the service in his area. "We pay ₹100-150 a month to private vendors. Now, the MCG is also charging us without providing the service," he said.

Mr. Singla added that homeowners had little

DLF City RWA general secretary Manish Dhawan said the issue was brought to the attention of area councillor Jyotsana Yadav, who raised it in a House meeting, but no resolution had come out of it. "We get many messages on WhatsApp groups with residents raising this issue," he said.

Residents and RWAs have demanded that the MCG either roll back the charge in areas without the service or first ensure that door-to-door collection and segregation is carried out before imposing the levy. They have called the current billing "double taxation" on households that are already paying private vendors for waste pickup.

Visakhapatnam man among three victims of attack on tanker

The Hindu Bureau
VISAKHAPATNAM

Patnala Suresh, a 44-year-old from Visakhapatnam, was among three Indian seafarers who were killed after the Palau-flagged tanker *MT Settebello* came under attack off the coast of Oman on June 10. Twenty-one other Indian crew members were rescued.

The death of the three crew members, who were initially reported missing, were confirmed on Thursday after their bodies were located and identified during search and rescue operations.

Speaking to a few news agencies and media houses, Suresh's wife Bhargavi said the family was informed that three crew members, including her husband, were missing following the incident. Till Thursday afternoon, they only knew that Suresh, chief engineer of the ship, was untraceable. Company officials later informed the family that the body had been recovered and identified.

Ms. Bhargavi said she had spoken to her husband for the last time on the night of June 9. According to her, Suresh had been planning to sign off from the vessel after spending nearly four months on board. He joined the ship at the end of January for what was initially expected to be a short assignment in China, but continued after the previous chief engineer signed off.

She said the vessel had



Bhargavi, wife of Patnala Suresh, shows his photograph on a mobile phone.

been operating in waters around China and Singapore before being directed towards the Gulf region. The family had expected the ship to return to China after loading cargo.

‘Expedite repatriation’
Seeking assistance from the authorities, Ms. Bhargavi appealed to the Central and State governments, as well as the Directorate General of Shipping, to expedite the repatriation of her husband's mortal remains and extend support to the family.

“He was the sole earning member of our family,” she said. A homemaker, Ms. Bhargavi said she has two children studying in Classes IX and VI and expressed concern about their education and future.

She added that company representatives had informed her that the necessary formalities were being completed through the embassies and in coordination with Indian authorities.

Efforts on to contain Nipah outbreak: Kerala Minister

Contact list of persons who might have interacted with the patient drawn up; no containment zone needed as none other than the patient had shown symptoms, says K. Muralaeeharan

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Health Department in Kerala is maintaining maximum vigilance and taking all possible preventive measures to ensure that the current Nipah outbreak in Kozhikode is contained and that no nosocomial or human-to-human transmission of the virus occurs.

The patient, a 43-year-old man from Ramanattukara, who was transferred from a private hospital to the Government Medical College Hospital (MCH), Kozhikode on Wednesday with encephalitis symptoms, is stable and on ventilator support.

Health Minister K. Mura-



Health workers at the Nipah isolation ward at the Government Medical College Hospital in Kozhikode on Thursday. K. RAGESH

leedharan, who spoke to mediapersons in Thiruvananthapuram on Thursday, after holding a high-level meeting with Health and medical college officials, said that a contact list of 77 persons who might have closely interacted

with the patient had been drawn up. The list includes 58 healthcare workers, 14 family members of the patient, and five co-workers and friends.

Of the 77 persons, two have been categorised as being at the “highest risk”,

13 at “high risk”, and 62 at low risk. He said that as of now, there was no need for earmarking a containment zone as none other than the patient had shown any symptoms.

The Health Department was preparing the patient's route map, and he appeared to have visited several healthcare establishments from May 10 before reaching the Kozhikode medical college, Mr. Muralaeeharan said.

The Rapid Response Team in Kozhikode had met and adequate stocks of personal protection equipment and medicines were being made available. A control room has been opened at Kozhikode district medical administration's office.



Newly elected BJP Rajya Sabha members with election certificates at the Madhya Pradesh Assembly on Thursday. A. M. FARUQUI

BJP's RS candidates in Madhya Pradesh elected unopposed

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL

Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) candidates Tarun Chug, Rajneesh Agrawal, and Mahesh Kewat were on Thursday declared elected unopposed to the three Rajya Sabha seats from Madhya Pradesh, even as the Congress challenged in the Supreme Court the rejection of nomination of its candidate, Meenakshi Natarajan.

Madhya Pradesh Legislative Assembly Principal Secretary Arvind Sharma, who is the Returning Officer (RO) for the election, issued election certificates to the three BJP candidates, prompting celebration in the party camp.

The Election Commission (EC), however, is yet to take a decision on the Congress's petition challenging the rejection of Ms. Natarajan's nomination for allegedly not disclosing a case in Hyderabad in which she had received a notice as a respondent.

The Congress accused

the RO and the ruling BJP of “seat theft”, while maintaining that Ms. Natarajan did not face any first information report or charges in the Telangana case and that she was thus not required to disclose it in the election affidavit.

Congress State president Jitu Patwari said the party MLAs from M.P. had sought time from President Droupadi Murmu on Friday to seek her intervention.

Outgoing Rajya Sabha member and senior Congress leader Digvijaya Singh demanded Mr. Sharma's dismissal, while terming the rejection “unconstitutional”. “Our worst fears have materialised. The EC has failed to reach a decision. We urged the Supreme Court to deliver a verdict today, but that did not happen. By 4 p.m., the election results were declared. We vehemently oppose this act of theft...,” Mr. Singh said.

SEE ALSO
» **PAGE 13**

Pinarayi's daughter seeks deferment of ED summons on health grounds

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

T. Veena, daughter of former Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, is unlikely to appear before the Kochi zonal office of the Enforcement Directorate (ED) for questioning on Friday in connection with the alleged money-laundering case linked to the Cochin Minerals and Rutile Limited (CMRL) pay-off case. She has sought postponement of appearance on health grounds.

The ED may issue a fresh summons for another date. Ms. Veena has reportedly mailed the agency, expressing her willingness to appear later



T. Veena

and cooperate with the investigation by submitting relevant documents through her lawyer.

This was the first summons issued to her by the ED, which is learnt to have prepared a detailed

questionnaire.

The Central agency had summoned Ms. Veena along with Sasidharan Kartha, chairman and managing director of CMRL, and senior company officials on June 9 as part of the probe.

The ED on May 27 searched Mr. Vijayan's residences in Kannur and Thiruvananthapuram as part of the probe into whether Ms. Veena's now-defunct firm Exalogic had received sizeable monthly retainers from the CMRL, a private mining company, between 2017 and 2021, allegedly without rendering any tangible service.

The ED had earlier frozen ₹18.36 crore in 242 ac-

counts identified during the search operations held in the pay-off case. It had claimed that the searches held as part of the probe yielded several incriminating records, accounts, digital evidence, and documents of investments and fixed deposits in banks. Besides Mr. Vijayan's residences, the ED had held searches in the residence of former Minister and Ms. Veena's husband, P.A. Mohamed Riyas.

A special court for the trial of Companies Act offences in Kochi on June 8 allowed the ED to obtain copies of documents collected by the SFIO in connection with the money-laundering case.

Supreme Court agrees to hear plea against Natarajan's rejection today

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court will hear on Friday a plea filed by Congress leader Meenakshi Natarajan challenging the rejection of her nomination papers for the Rajya Sabha election in Madhya Pradesh.

A Bench of Justices Prashant Kumar Mishra and A.S. Chandurkar agreed to take up the matter following an oral request by senior advocate Abhishek Singhvi. The Bench, however, declined to grant any interim relief preventing the declaration of the election result, observing that courts should ordinarily not intervene



Congress leader Meenakshi Natarajan. FILE PHOTO

once the electoral process has commenced.

“Sorry, we cannot. We are posting it tomorrow, subject to clearance of all defects,” the Bench told Mr. Singhvi, who urged the court to pass an interim order preventing the authorities from declaring the result pending adjudication

of the plea.

The move came amid concerns raised by the Congress that Thursday was the final day for withdrawal of nominations. The party pointed out that with Ms. Natarajan out of the fray, the BJP candidates could be elected unopposed after the withdrawal

deadline expired. “Today is the last day of withdrawal. They are technically entitled to declare the result after the deadline to withdraw nomination ends later today because it would be unopposed,” Mr. Singhvi, said, urging the Bench at least to direct the authorities not to declare the result till the matter was heard.

Contending that the rejection of Ms. Natarajan's nomination was legally untenable, senior counsel argued that the criminal proceedings relied upon by the Returning Officer had not advanced to the stage where a competent court had taken cognisance of the complaint.

Kharge, three others unanimously elected to RS in Karnataka

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

All the four candidates who had filed their nominations for the Rajya Sabha elections from Karnataka, including AICC president Mallikarjun Kharge, have been declared unanimously elected.

Legislative Assembly Secretary M.K. Vishalakshi, the Returning Officer for the Rajya Sabha polls, issued a statement on Thursday declaring them elected unanimously.

The other three candidates are Pawan Khara and Mansoor Ali Khan, who had contested on Congress ticket, and M. Nagaraja, a BJP nominee.

The other candidates are Pawan Khara, Mansoor Ali Khan from Cong., and M. Nagaraja from BJP

The polling for these seats was scheduled to be held on June 18. However, the need for polling did not arise as there were only four candidates in the fray as against equal number of vacancies.

The biennial elections had been necessitated owing to the retirement of former Prime Minister H.D. Deve Gowda. Mr. Kharge, and BJP members Iranna Kadadi and Narayana Koragappa on June 25.

Challenges loom for Karnataka govt. ahead of second Cabinet expansion

Nagesh Prabhu
BENGALURU

As the Congress government headed by D.K. Shivakumar prepares for the second phase of the Cabinet expansion, the biggest challenge before the Chief Minister is balancing competing political interests within the party.

The first round of the Cabinet formation triggered open dissent, suggesting that the next expansion could prove to be even more complicated.

Over a dozen Congress MLAs are already camping in New Delhi, meeting the party's top leadership and lobbying for ministerial berths. Many of them view the upcoming expansion as a do-or-die opportunity.



Karnataka Cabinet Ministers during the oath-taking ceremony of the first batch of Ministers in Bengaluru on June 3. PTI

Former Ministers B.Z. Zameer Ahmed Khan, Santosh Lad, and N. Cheluvarayaswamy have reportedly met the party high command seeking Cabinet berths. The expansion is expected by the end of June after the elections to seven seats of the Legisla-

tive Council.

Meanwhile, discontentment continues to simmer within the government over the allocation of portfolios. In addition, caste organisations, religious seers, and supporters have been demanding the inclusion of MLAs from their

respective communities in the Cabinet through protests, press conferences, and banner campaigns.

The first Cabinet reflected a power-sharing arrangement, with several key portfolios going to loyalists of former Chief Minister Siddaramaiah. Any perception that the next expansion disproportionately favours Mr. Shivakumar loyalists could revive factional tensions.

The absence of women in the initial Cabinet has also drawn criticism from Congress leaders such as Margaret Alva. Mr. Shivakumar has indicated that women legislators could be accommodated in the next round, increasing pressure on the leadership to reserve berths for them.

Telangana Congress alleges ‘dirty politics’ in RS nomination row

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Telangana Pradesh Congress Committee working president T. Jagga Reddy questioned the ‘dirty’ politics of the Bharatiya Janata Party to prevent senior Congress leader Meenakshi Natarajan from entering the Rajya Sabha.

Addressing a press conference here on Thursday, he said that Ms. Natarajan was deliberately targeted by the BJP during the Rajya Sabha election process in Madhya Pradesh. Rejection of the nomination is based on an unregistered case, he said, questioning the legitimacy of such a decision.



T. Jagga Reddy

Responding to criticism from BRS leaders, he alleged that while the BJP was responsible for the controversy, BRS was attempting to shift blame onto the Congress. “BJP committed the wrongdoing, while BRS is throwing mud at Congress leaders,” he remarked.



Charbagh railway station in Lucknow, as thousands of candidates come in and leave after appearing for the Uttar Pradesh Police Constable Examination between June 8 and 10. SANDEEP SAXENA

When hope and desperation collide

With over 28 lakh youths applying for a little over 32,000 constable-rank positions in Uttar Pradesh, the focus is back on employment opportunities and the increasing number of young degree holders in the State, reports **Mayank Kumar**

Vishal Maurya boarded the Ganga Sutlej Express at Akbarpur Junction in Uttar Pradesh (U.P.) on June 8. The 22-year-old was headed to Lucknow, 194 kilometres away by rail. Across the seven-hour journey, what played in Maurya's head on loop was a plea. All he wanted was to pass the constable-rank examination to be held on June 10 in Uttar Pradesh's capital.

Maurya is from Ghughurpatti in Amedkar Nagar district, and passed out of school four years ago. If he gets through the test, he hopes to change the lives of his parents and lift generations of disadvantages off their shoulders.

His parents work as agricultural labourers in their village, and don't own land. "When they find work, they earn ₹300. I aspire to change their fortunes. I studied diligently for the exam, inspired by my online teacher who shares motivational stories of youths from similar backgrounds who have succeeded in becoming constables," Maurya said. He added that for generations they had "lived a life of inferiority". This was an opportunity "for people like us to change our lives". Maurya is a first-generation learner. He works part-time as a construction labourer.

On June 9, he was in Lucknow's Charbagh railway station, with thousands of others who had arrived to take the exam. Charbagh is Lucknow's main railway station, situated in the heart of the U.P. capital, just 3 km from Hazratganj, the downtown area and main shopping centre of Lucknow. Hazratganj remained overcrowded with candidates for the U.P. constable posts written examination. Held across June 8-10, all trains departing from or arriving at the station were fully booked. Thousands of U.P. constable aspirants stand on the floors, with many sitting in the lavatories of the trains. On the platforms, there is barely any space to walk. Thousands queue up to charge their phones via a few dozen charging points.

In the last week of December, 2025, U.P. notified 32,679 posts of police constables and equivalent positions, the lowest category of the workforce under the State police force. The registration process, which began on December 31, 2025, and ended on January 30, 2026, led to 28.86 lakh aspirants filling the form to appear in the written test at 1,183 centres across 75 districts. More than 1.35 lakh candidates were allocated test centres in Lucknow.

The platform of possibility

At the train station, Maurya's story found resonance with a stranger, Vaibhav Chaudhary, 24, from Gorakhpur, a B.Tech graduate in Computer Science. Screen-locking his OPPO A3x5G smartphone, he said, "Everyone in this sea of people has a story filled with urgency, desperation, hope, and aspiration for this job. While taking the exam, I thought of my 15-year-old sister and the need to provide her with better educational opportunities, so she won't have to struggle as I did."

Chaudhary battled the 40 degrees Celsius heat in a yellow vest. He was returning from Barabanki, about 20 km from Lucknow, after taking the recruitment examination. To be eligible to qualify, people must be between 18 and 27 years, depending on the job, gender, and reservation, and have passed class 12, the highest school examination.

Chaudhary works as a gig worker in Gorakhpur.



A constable's job is much better than poorly paid engineering jobs. It provides job security and stability and includes attractive perks and social security benefits, like medical insurance and gratuity.

VAIBHAV CHAUDHARY
Gig worker in Gorakhpur

pur. He says there are barely any private-sector office jobs that match his education. "I was offered a ₹20,000 job in an IT firm in Noida. It was impossible to survive there on such a low salary," he said. Noida is in U.P. and is a part of the National Capital Region. "A constable's job is much better than poorly paid engineering jobs. It provides job security and stability and includes attractive perks and social security benefits, like medical insurance and gratuity." His parents are marginal farmers with four acres of land.

The platforms were full of stories of people coming in for exams, or leaving after, or coming back after writing them. "I intentionally missed five trains before boarding the Suhaildev Superfast express, but I still had to travel in the bathroom," said Pushpesh Kumar, 21, a second-year BA English Literature student who took online coaching for the test. He took the exam because "There are hardly any job opportunities for English graduates. I am working as a private tutor, making ends meet, preparing for government jobs." His plan B is a government teaching job, "but that is a long road as I need to do a B. Ed (Bachelor's in Education)."

Sensing the massive influx of candidates, U.P. Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath instructed the Uttar Pradesh State Road Transport Corporation (UPSRTC) to provide 50% concession on fares to candidates appearing for the examination. They simply had to present their admit cards to bus conductors. Despite this, the public transport system was overcrowded for at least three days in the State, with many passengers having pre-booked train tickets complaining of not being able to board the train because of the huge rush of young aspirants at multiple railway junctions.

Testing, testing

Over 21.92 lakh aspirants appeared in the examination. The written test consisted of 150 objective-type multiple-choice questions of two marks each. The written examination syllabus was divided into four sections: General Studies, General Hindi, Numerical and Mental Ability tests, and Reasoning.

The Uttar Pradesh Police Recruitment and Promotion Board (UPPRPB), the recruiting agency, will prepare a list of shortlisted candidates who passed the written test on a date yet to be

announced. Since 2008, the UPPRPB has been entrusted to conduct selections for various non-gazetted posts, including that of the U.P. constable. A senior Indian Police Service (IPS) officer as Chairman of the agency heads and oversees all the activities that occur in the board.

The second stage is the Physical Standard Test (PST), where height will be checked. For general and Other Backward Class (OBC) male candidates, the minimum height requirement is 168 cm, while the minimum chest measurement requirement is 79 cm (without expansion) and 84 cm (with expansion). For general and OBC females, the minimum height requirement is 152 cm and the minimum weight is 40 kilograms.

In the final stage, the candidates need to make it through a physical efficiency test, in which men must run a distance of 4.8 km in 25 minutes and female candidates 2.4 km in 14 minutes. A new entrant will earn roughly ₹21,700 a month, with a slew of benefits enjoyed by government servants.

Struggle and hope

A section of the candidates appearing in the recruitment drive hails from farming families fighting to make ends meet in the Hindi headland. A large number is also from the educated, salaried section of society.

Aman Singh, 22, is a BSc Biotechnology degree holder from Basti district in eastern U.P. His father is a retired teacher who taught classes 11 and 12. "I worked in a Dehradun-based firm for a few months. I filed the constable form as it is free from private sector volatility and provides protection against lay offs," he said. Singh added that he left his job as the wages were only ₹18,000 per month. "The company believes there is a massive oversupply of labour, hence at the entry-level, they keep salaries low and stagnant. Now, I live with my family in Basti, and I am preparing for government jobs."

Up to 9.24 lakh women candidates filed the form, with the majority of them being accompanied by at least one male family member in the journey.

Rachna Yadav, 24, from Lucknow, who has a BA in Economics, and teaches in a private school, has a similar story to tell. "In the private sector, we get informal and poorly-paid jobs." Her father, who is an electrician, was carrying the luggage, protecting her from the crowd. He said, "For people like us, a government job is the only way towards upward social and economic mobility. Every person who is appearing is a struggler here; their family is struggling in this materialistic world."

Vibhuti Narain Rai, a 1975-batch IPS officer from the Uttar Pradesh cadre, served as the Director General of Police until he retired. He says, in rural parts of the State, only a *sarkari naukari* (government job), even if it's at the lowest rung, is considered a job, as it commands respect and authority in society.

"In a volatile economic scenario, *sarkari naukari* is a life-long safety net, whereas in private jobs opportunities are shrinking and instability is common," he said. "Two people at the same level will get one-third the pay in a private job. I was vice-chancellor of a central university, and out of eight drivers, four were permanently appointed through a recruitment exercise. They were getting over ₹45,000 as salary, apart from social security benefits. The four drivers who were hired on a temporary basis were getting hardly ₹18,000 without benefits. People want to be fully em-

ployed by the government."

Someone selected for a constable position may rise to the post of Inspector in the State police force after serving about 25 years in the police service. He said the first two years are a probation period. It generally takes 5-8 years in service to be promoted to the position of head constable, then 5-8 years in service for promotion to sub-inspector. A team of a constable, a head constable, and an Assistant Sub-Inspector form the backbone of the police. "They are the first to reach the spot in a law-and-order situation," Rai said. It's the constable's job to maintain ties with local informers.

A symbol of desperation

Critics alleged that the staggering number of job seekers signifies multiple challenges facing Uttar Pradesh. "Over 80 candidates competing for one constable post is a marker of many crises in the State. It points to the fact that the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)-led government failed in generating employment opportunities for millions of young people in the State," said Udai Veer Singh, the Samajwadi Party (SP) spokesperson. He added that the government makes claims of investment from big companies, but nothing is changing on the ground. "With constant paper leaks, the youth are wasting away their years. Well-qualified people are applying for low-pay jobs under frustration," he said.

Pushing for a transparent and stringent examination system, in view of past instances of irregularities, the recruitment board made comprehensive security arrangements and took legal action against those attempting to compromise the integrity of the examination. The Recruitment Board, on June 8, registered cases at Husainganj police station against the Telegram channel 'UPP Exam Paper' and the Instagram account 'UP Police Leak' for their alleged involvement in selling a fake question paper claiming it had been leaked. In Azamgarh, a case was registered against Instagram user Ashutosh Kumar Maurya for allegedly doing the same. He was taken into custody.

Sharat Pradhan, a veteran political commentator based in Lucknow, calls the huge rush for the constable job a symbol of desperation among the youth. "It points towards a kind of distress and humongous failure of the system in employment generation. If a BA pass-out in English, or a B. Tech degree holder is competing for constable jobs in the police force, it shows the overall system is not generating opportunities to utilise their skills and education," added Pradhan.

Ajit Kumar Jha, an Oxford University-trained political and social analyst who has followed U.P. closely for four decades, says the State needs to put in place emergency steps to generate employment opportunities. "This shows a structural problem with U.P.'s economy, as a large population is unemployed or underemployed. Many among them are skilled youths," he said.

He said the crisis is all the more serious because U.P. is a State with a low median age due to fertility rates (2.4 between 2019-21 and 2.2 between 2023-24; India's was 2 for both periods). U.P.'s median age is 24.7 years, among the lowest in India, as per the Government of India data.

"Uttar Pradesh needs an industrial and manufacturing revolution to fix the crisis. It cannot be done only by generating service-sector jobs," Jha said.

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Candidates outside an examination centre in Lucknow, where they sat for the test to qualify as a constable. SANDEEP SAXENA



Beyond pride and prejudice

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For a face tailored for romantic comedies, actor Ali Fazal constantly resists typecasting by leaning into gritty, morally ambiguous characters, where circumstances keep the audience from falling for his charming appearance. The latest is *Raakh*, where the actor plays a junior police officer investigating a double murder, stripping away the stereotypical crutches of Dalit identity in Jaiprakash Javav.

“The identity is right there on his uniform nameplate, but I understand that, unfortunately, the real people who are living out those lives are not allowed to underline their existence. Somewhere it has been beautifully written into the script and comes through seamlessly through his relationship with his father, food, and the system.”

Having grown up in Lucknow, where his grandfather was a seasoned politician, Ali has not only imbibed the language and culture of the region but also come to understand the treacherous social divisions. “It definitely found reflection in the character. I mean,

Ali Fazal on playing a Dalit police officer in *Raakh*, a series inspired by the infamous Geeta and Sanjay Chopra case that shook Delhi in the 1970s

what an entire generation of people has gone through.”

He comes up with “*zapt karna*,” the precise phrase in Urdu that explains how men in marginalised societies are expected to control or restrain their emotions. “They play to the gallery, but deep inside, they carry a lot of angst. I find myself privileged, but I have tried to bring it out in little things like how JP takes extra care of the last crease on his uniform on what could be his last day on the case.”

There is an interesting scene where JP tells his father, who had served as a havildar in the police department, that there is a difference between respect and

flattery because he feels his father tries to curry favour with seniors by serving them his tasty mutton recipe. “*Log khisiya jaate hain*. People get piqued when their pride is bruised.” Ali urges, irrespective of social hierarchy, “everybody should have access to pride”.

Co-creator and writer Sandeep Saket adds that, while the father is a survivor, the son does not want to be stuck in a state of victimhood. Inspired by the infamous Geeta and Sanjay Chopra case that shook Delhi in the late 1970s, the series comments on Delhi’s transition from a repository of flora and fauna to becoming a hideout for animals in

A city in transition Stills from *Raakh*. PRIME VIDEO



human skin. Co-creator Anusha Nandakumar says that dialogue writer Ayush (Trivedi) came up with the line during a discussion about Khushwant Singh’s writing, who made the comparison in one of his works. “The messaging comes at a tender moment, and that’s why it rings true”.

We don’t know much about Ranga and Billa, but the series looks at the origins of the perpetrators of the fictionalised Babu and Rajjo. “We tend to believe that all villains are alpha males. What if one of them is a beta carrying its complex?” says Sandeep.

Outside his comfort zone

On his choices, even in a rom-com like *Metro...In Dino*, it is not easy to like his character, Ali says, as much as he loves rom coms, he gets bored with himself easily.

“I want to make myself and people uncomfortable. So, whenever a well-written part comes my way, I lap it up. I am not too excited about mapping my journey for the next two to three years. I am not desperate to climb a peak by

I guess we have great storytellers, but when it comes to finalising ideas and collaborations, imagination goes for a toss, and we settle for a formula

ALI FAZAL
Actor

following a certain path. From a young age, I was exposed to foreign cinema. I understand there are many (cinematic) worlds out there and I want to be part of them,” says the actor who found global attention with Stephen Frears’ *Victoria & Abdul*.

Director Prosit Roy says he finds Ali very secure as a person. “And that’s why he can experiment.”

Part of the reason, Ali reveals, is that he, along with his wife, actor Richa Chaddha, turned to production (with the critically acclaimed *Girls Will Be Girls*) to cut through the industry’s reluctance to make the audience uncomfortable. “I guess we have great storytellers, but when it comes to finalising ideas and collaborations, imagination goes for a toss, and we settle for a formula. It seems everybody is scared, everybody is concerned about their kitchen. But how long will it be a safe bet? I guess we are not being fair to the art form,” he says, quickly underlining that it is still early as far as production is concerned. “Let two or three films come out. Then we would know where we stand.”

Up next is the film version of his popular OTT series *Mirzapur*. Is it worth telling the same story all over again? “Honestly speaking, it is not required, but we are doing it. It is an experiment, and there might be space for it. Let’s see....” says Ali with a hearty laugh.

Raakh is currently streaming on Prime Video.

STEPOUT



Fresh perspectives

Emerging Visions brings together works by students of the National Institute of Fine Arts, showcasing paintings, drawings, sculptures, and mixed-media works. Featuring students from the institute’s diploma and degree programmes, the exhibition highlights emerging artistic voices and the diverse themes they are exploring, from identity and memory to contemporary life and abstraction. The show offers a platform for young artists at the start of their professional journeys. *Emerging Visions will be on view until June 16, between 11am and 7pm, at the Main Gallery, Bikaner House.*



K-Pop calling

As K-pop’s fan culture continues to grow in India, HYBE India is bringing the final stop of its Pop-up Park tour to Delhi. Open to female participants born between 2005 and 2011, the auditions are part of a 15-city talent search spanning singing, dance, rap, and modelling. The Pop-up Park features fan activities, dance sessions, and a live performance by Reble, known for *Dhurandhar*. *Auditions will take place on June 14 from 10am at Shangri-La Eros New Delhi, while the Pop-up Park runs on June 13 and 14 from 2pm at Yashobhoomi.*

Delhi’s island detour

Zetu introduces the capital’s diners to contemporary Sri Lankan cuisine in a Geoffrey Bawa-inspired space

Deepali Dhingra

They say it is always cooler under a banyan tree. Sitting in the open expanse of Zetu, the new contemporary Sri-Lankan restaurant at 1AQ in Mehrauli, we find ourselves agreeing with this ancient wisdom. Surrounded by lush greenery and tropical architecture inspired by legendary Sri Lankan architect Geoffrey Bawa, the space feels sophisticated yet unpretentious. Derived from Setu – the Sanskrit word for bridge – the founders Sarah Nikahetiya, Anurag Dania, Abhishek Mathur and Sagar Garg – gave the name a “zingy Z” to give it a sharper, modern ring.

Sarah, a former diplomat with the British High Commission stayed in Delhi for a couple of years, and fell in love with the capital before moving to Colombo, Sri Lanka. The idea for Zetu took shape during her frequent flights back and forth across the ocean. “That little string of islands between the two countries is the last thing you see when you exit Sri Lankan airspace. We wanted to capture that conversation between modern Delhi and Sri Lanka, not just through food, but through the design as well,” she says.

When it comes to the food, there is a sense of storytelling on the plate, culled from actual Sri Lankan home kitchens. Chef Dush Ratnayake from Sri Lanka leads the way, while Indian chefs Mohit Kumar and Romil Malhotra keep the massive 175-seater running smoothly.

We begin our meal with choon paan butter flight – baked bread served with a trio of flavoured butters; tandoori, nori and citrus, and curry lead pesto. Pillow fight, is salmon and avocado on puffed rice, an ode to the pillow fights of Sri Lanka’s new year celebrations. The dish however lacks the punchy execution of the starters that preceded it. The



Bridging cultures The ambience at Zetu. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

hardest thing to make on the menu, according to Chef Dush, is the lamprais, though it looks the simplest. Wrapped in a banana leaf, the spiced rice with brinjal and seeni sambol is packed with meatballs and chicken gravy. We end the meal with a guava tart baked with a delicate lemon curd and raisin puree.

The cocktails continue this exploration of Sri Lankan ingredients and flavour profiles. The frangipani Martini impresses with its delicate gin and frangipani infusion, while the gin-based Kandyan Negroni with rambutan infused campari and sweet vermouth has a fiery red glow and is beautifully dialled down with the fruit’s sweetness. Stepping out of Zetu and walking past the banyan tree again, we feel the bridge between Sri Lanka and Delhi has narrowed a little.

Zetu is at 1AQ, Seth Sarai, Mehrauli and is open from noon to midnight. A meal for two costs ₹8,000 without alcohol. For reservations call 8796056111.



The OTT way Manoj Bajpayee in a still from *Governor*. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Never back down

Actor Manoj Bajpayee, whose *Governor* hit screens this week, addresses the problem of the relentless chase for box office numbers

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In times of scarcity, you find creative ways to express yourself,” says Manoj Bajpayee, joining the huge number of people having an opinion about the latest sensation, *Obsession*. The veteran actor sees the monstrous hit psychological thriller as a hope for independent cinema, a format he has always supported.

“In India, there are no mentors for independent movies. Every indie filmmaker faces the struggle of exhibiting their work,” he adds. “That said, the young generation is well-equipped with technology. They are making short fictions on reels. Look at *Obsession*, it’s

the best example to not lose hope in independent cinema.”

Bajpayee is gearing up for the release of *Governor*, a theatrical film based on India’s financial crisis in the early 1990s. He plays S Venkitaramanan, the former Governor of the Reserve Bank of India, who battled national bankruptcy to rescue the country’s economy. Releasing today, the Hindi movie is directed by Chinmay D Mandlekar.

In the last decade or so, Bajpayee has seamlessly balanced his career between theatrical and OTT spaces, and he has sharp observations about the changing nature of the formats. “We should stop talking about box office returns. That’s one change I want to see in Bollywood,” he opines. “Only the producer should be worried

about numbers. Managing money is his area of expertise, and he should deal with it. Audiences and film critics must talk about the craft. And directors and actors must focus on delivering a quality movie. We must stick to our roles.”

With the debut season of *The Family Man* in 2019, Bajpayee

We should stop talking about box office returns. That’s one change I want to see in Bollywood. Only the producer should be worried about numbers. Audiences and film critics must talk about the craft

MANOJ BAJPAYEE
Actor

reinvented his career. The OTT space gave the gifted actor a second wind. Today, Bajpayee feels that people are experiencing fatigue with OTT shows. “I fear that OTT is going the TV way,” he points out. “Somewhere, people who run the OTT platforms are conscious about reaching everybody in the household. The moment you think like that, you are going the TV way. *The Family Man* stayed true to its genre yet had unique elements. You must always look to break new ground in the OTT space.”

He says further, “When you explore the freedom a platform gives, the results will be wonderful. I essayed several complex characters.”

For Bajpayee, it wasn’t easy to play Venkitaraman, the man who managed an unprecedented financial emergency during a period of extreme political turnover. He had to understand the historic episode as well as know the approach of Venkitaraman to the crisis to bring out the character convincingly.

“Without confusing viewers with too many statistics, we want to tell them how the country was on the verge of bankruptcy and how one underdog responds to the difficult situation.”

With *Governor*, Bajpayee seems to be done with complex characters. “I want to enjoy on the sets,” he laughs. “I want to play a fun character who sings and makes people laugh.” That doesn’t mean he intends to star in the next big-budget ‘masala’ film. “Big-budget movies don’t attract me. What matters to me is the story and the scope for performance, and not the scale.”

Governor releases in theatres on June 12



Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Percentage increase in bank credit in May 2026

17 in per cent. Bank credit grew 17.44% year-on-year in May, marking the ninth consecutive month of double-digit expansion, reflecting sustained demand for loans from both retail and corporate borrowers, according to the latest Reserve Bank data. Since January 31 this year, credit growth has stayed above 13% and ranged between 14 and 17% thereafter. PTI

Opportunities presented by India’s data centre ecosystem

280 in \$ billion. Driven by the AI boom and rapid digital transformation, India’s data centre value chain is projected to generate a potential order book of \$280 billion by 2035, according to consulting firm PwC. While direct investments to build core data centre facilities are estimated at \$71.6 billion by 2035, the broader ecosystem offers a larger opportunity. PTI

Estimated increase in India’s horticulture production in 2025-26

2 in per cent. India’s horticulture production is estimated to rise 2% to 377.77 million tonnes during the 2025-26 crop year, mainly on better output of fruits and vegetables, according to government data. According to an official statement, the area under horticulture crops stood at 301.51 lakh hectare in 2025-26, a marginal increase from 301.36 lakh hectare in the preceding year. PTI

People killed in drone strikes on the key Sudan city of El-Obeid

23 Drone strikes on the strategic Sudanese city of El-Obeid killed 23 people, a rights group and witnesses said on Thursday. The Emergency Lawyers group said the attack on the key hub in the southern Kordofan region began on Wednesday evening and continued into Thursday, striking residential areas, a funeral gathering and a truck carrying food supplies. AP

Migrants from India, Pakistan, Bangladesh to Gulf since 2010

19 million. A study has estimated that about 19 million people, averaging 1.35 million per year, have migrated from India, Pakistan, and Bangladesh to Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Bahrain, and the UAE since 2010. Globally, West Asia experienced the highest total inflow of migrants, chiefly from South Asia and the Philippines. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Why is Nicobar debating elections?

Why are Nicobarese tribal councils wary of the administration's proposed election rules? How are Nicobarese leaders chosen today, and what changes do the draft rules propose? Why does the administration want formal elections for tribal councils? How could the proposed rules change Nicobarese self-governance?

EXPLAINER

Abhinay Lakshman

The story so far:

The centrally administered Union Territory of Andaman and Nicobar Islands is planning to introduce elections, as they are conducted in the rest of India, to the Nicobarese tribal community’s system of self-governance in the archipelago. This includes measures such as the delimitation of constituencies, the preparation of electoral rolls, and the reservation of seats and leadership positions for women in the community’s tribal councils. This move has led to urgent discussions amongst existing tribal councils of the Nicobarese about how this might bureaucratised the governance they have been practising. Some have also suspected that it could be intended to have tribal councils that might be more favourable to the Union government’s interests there, especially in Great Nicobar, where the current Nicobarese leadership has been opposing the Centre’s ₹91,000 crore container port, airport, and tourist-townfield project.

What do the draft rules propose?

The draft Andaman and Nicobar Islands Tribal Councils (Preparation of Electoral Rolls and Conduct of Elections) Rules, 2026, was notified by the district administration on May 15 this year and prescribes the exact procedure and rules for conducting 5-yearly elections to the Village Councils and Tribal Councils. The draft rules provide for conducting elections, the structure of the new representative system, the manner in which seats and constituencies are to be delimited, the rules for candidature, nomination, and withdrawal, their duties and responsibilities, and the broader administrative set-up for conducting these elections.

The proposed structure involves Nicobarese villagers electing five to nine Captains for each village and directly voting for the position of the Chief Captain of each Island Tribal Council. The First Captains of each village of a particular Island are to vote for the position of the Vice-Chief Captain of the Island Tribal Council, and this Island Tribal Council would include the Chief Captain, the Vice-Chief Captain, and all First Captains of the Island.

These draft rules have been notified under the Andaman and Nicobar Islands (Tribal Councils) Regulation, a Presidential regulation promulgated in 2009 with the specific intent to bring autonomous self-governance to the Nicobarese community. Even though this Regulation provided the statutory language to set up the Village Council and Tribal Council structure, a key feature of this Regulation gave the district administration (through the Deputy Commissioner and Assistant Commissioner) an absolute and unilateral veto over any decision of the councils, if they posed a threat of injury or “annoyance” to the public or might “lead to a breach of peace”.

Since the 2009 Regulation was passed, there have been several attempts at notifying Draft Rules under it, the latest one in 2020. The past iterations of the draft have often been circulated among tribal council leaders, but the leadership has not been able to successfully communicate the essence of these rules and procedures to the community at large.



The Tribal Welfare Department of the A&NI administration has said that it will wait till June 15 for suggestions and objections. FILE PHOTO

Even though the Nicobarese community has been participating in Lok Sabha elections, according to officials from the Office of the CEO, Andaman and Nicobar Islands, this would be the first time a system of constituency-wise representative leadership structure will be implemented for Nicobarese self-governance if the Draft Rules are finalised.

How do the Nicobarese tribal councils function today?

The Nicobarese community, a designated Scheduled Tribe with a total population of about 30,000 across the Nicobar group of Islands, is traditionally represented by Tribal Councils that have been established over the last five to six decades. Each group of inhabited islands in the Nicobar has its own Tribal Council. Under this Tribal Council structure lies the village leadership, which comprises three Captains per village, headed by the First Captain and assisted by the Second and Third Captains. Including the Tribal Council of Little and Great Nicobar, seven Tribal Councils represent the Nicobarese community in islands like Car Nicobar, Nancowry, Kamorta, Teressa, and others.

Since at least the mid-1970s, experts and scholars have observed that the Nicobarese have been picking village captains through adult franchise. The concept of captaincy as village leadership first emerged in the 16th Century, when the Nicobarese who would go on board passing ships of colonial empires to negotiate began calling themselves captains. The British colonists were, however, the first to start legitimising the Captaincy structure as representative leadership of the community for their own administrative advantage towards the end of the 19th Century.

This structure eventually developed into a supplement to the social structure of large joint families, often referred to as *Tuhets*, that could become a formal channel of communication with the government.

The idea of the tribal council, however, emerged only in the 1990s to facilitate and ease the community’s entry into Government developmental activities, specifically in relation to a Central government scheme of the time for poverty alleviation. Today, the Nicobar district says that the Village leadership and the tribal councils have become “the

link between the Local Administration and the tribal people of the island... most of the developmental schemes are being implemented through them only”.

How are leaders currently chosen in Nicobarese communities?

Even though authorities in the Nicobar district administration have maintained that under the current system, village captains are usually elected every four years, Anthropologist and community leader Anstice Justin has told The Hindu that “there is actually not much documentation on how exactly the leadership of the existing tribal councils operate”.

A senior leader of the Tribal Council in Great Nicobar Island explained that elections for Captains and Tribal Council chairperson are held whenever the community feels the need for it. This leader, who is also the First Captain of his village on Great Nicobar Island, elaborated, “For example, the last time I was elected Captain was maybe around 2-3 years ago. There is a tradition in our community to get together for a village meeting. All residents of the village are present at this meeting.”

The villagers then nominate names for the Captains of the village through popular consensus. These names are then put on a ballot paper. “We make the ballot papers and print them out ourselves, we appoint a polling officer from among us to conduct the ballot, and the person with the most votes becomes First Captain.” He added that similarly, the Tribal Council on GNI has been choosing the Chairperson by popular consensus, but that it had been decades since there was an election to this position.

Villagers mostly think about candidates’ level of education, fluency in Hindi (the language of government officials), “foreign” trips (an indicator of exposure to the world outside the islands), and “smartness” (the ability to deal appropriately with officials and outsiders, according to R. Venkat Ramanujam, Simron Jit Singh & Arild Vatn (2012). What Ramanujam et. al. noted, however, was that even though the Captains and Council were elected, “decisions were taken after popular consultation, usually through community meetings, and the tribal council did not have unilateral decision-making powers. Consequently, the captains were neither

seen as lawmakers nor as “leaders” balancing social and political concerns.”

Why are the proposed changes causing concern?

Tribal Council leaders who have spoken to *The Hindu* about the implications of the new Draft Rules said that the proposed structure is largely being seen as something that would disrupt their traditional ways of perceiving governance. The tribal council leader from Great Nicobar said, “We have been using this way of governing our villages for generations. We hold elections through consensus when needed, and our traditional ways of living are so well integrated into how we oversee the islands and villages. This looks like it will turn all of this into an office job that we will have to do in addition to the lives we live on the islands.”

Meanwhile, Mr. Justin has noted that there is a real chance that an attempt to notify the Rules has come now in light of the opposition the government is facing from the Tribal Council on GNI, even though he acknowledged that systemic problems of opacity have riddled the existing system of Tribal Councils and Village Captaincy. “For instance, in several Island Tribal Councils, it remains unclear when the Chairperson was last elected and what kind of authority they wield,” he said.

But experts like Mr. Justin, who have worked with the government on engaging with the indigenous communities of the A&NI, have doubted whether the entire Nicobarese community in the islands will have the time and resources to understand the Draft Rules as they have been notified, the context of the Regulation under which they will be implemented, and the implications of introducing such a system for their village-level governance.

The Tribal Welfare Department of the A&NI administration has said that it will wait till June 15 for suggestions and objections, after which a final version may be notified. While the Tribal Councils of Nicobar are yet to hand in a formal objection or suggestions, the Congress party in A&NI has already objected to them and called for their withdrawal, primarily citing the lack of recognition for the Tuhet system and the lack of consultation with the community before bringing this draft.

THE GIST

▼ Draft rules propose formal elections for Nicobarese Village and Tribal Councils, including constituencies, voter rolls, and reservations for women.

▼ Traditional governance is consensus-based, with village captains chosen through community meetings and locally conducted ballots rather than a fixed bureaucratic electoral system.

▼ Tribal leaders fear the proposed electoral system could bureaucratised their traditional governance structure and alter existing decision-making processes.

IN THE LIMELIGHT



A still from ‘Close Encounters of the Third Kind’ COLUMBIA PICTURES

Before ‘Disclosure Day’: how first-contact cinema taught us to imagine the Third Kind

For over a century, science fiction has used aliens to talk about empire, paranoia, language, and power – here is how first-contact cinema became a mirror for humanity’s shifting fears and ambitions

Ayaan Paul Chowdhury

When Steven Spielberg releases *Disclosure Day* today, his first alien film in over two decades, he will be returning to the obsession that helped define his career. The veteran American filmmaker who transformed Devils Tower, Wyoming, into a beacon for cosmic pilgrims in *Close Encounters of the Third Kind* and turned a homesick alien into a beloved cultural icon in *E.T. the Extra-Terrestrial*, now finds himself at a curious moment in history. Unidentified aerial phenomena (UAP), the bureaucratically sanitised successor to the UFO, have migrated from grainy VHS footage to very serious U.S. congressional hearings and Pentagon investigations. The border between conspiracy theories and institutional scrutiny has grown increasingly porous of late, placing Spielberg’s prodigal return alongside a broader public reckoning with the oldest question in the cosmos: are we alone?

Though ostensibly focused on extraterrestrial life, first-contact stories have consistently explored humanity’s attempts to understand forces beyond familiar systems of knowledge. Across more than a century, extraterrestrials have played the roles of invaders, gods, refugees, mirrors, parasites, colonial powers, ecological warnings, and philosophical riddles. The shape of the alien has changed with each generation because the fears and aspirations projected onto it have evolved with time.

The earliest modern template came in 1898 when H.G. Wells published *The War of the Worlds*. Wells instinctively understood something many later imitators would spend decades rediscovering – the terror of contact emerged from powerlessness. His Martian invaders treated humanity with the same

brutal apathy European empires had shown colonised peoples across Africa, Asia, and the Americas. The novel appeared during the height of British imperial expansion, yet its staying power came from forcing readers to imagine themselves on the receiving end of that violent conquest.

Alien invasion cinema throughout the 20th century inherited those anxieties, and the Cold War accelerated that trend. American sci-fi films of the 1950s turned extraterrestrials into vessels for political paranoia because the possibility of nuclear annihilation and ideological infiltration already influenced public consciousness. Don Siegel’s *Invasion of the Body Snatchers* imagined entire communities replaced by emotionless duplicates, reflecting fears surrounding communist infiltration during the McCarthy era. Even hopeful films carried atomic-age dread. Robert Wise’s original *The Day the Earth Stood Still* presented Klaatu as a benevolent visitor, yet his message centred on nuclear brinkmanship because the probability of self-destruction had become impossible to ignore.

By the late 1960s, first-contact cinema began asking different questions. Space exploration had expanded public imagination while Vietnam and Watergate weakened faith in institutions. Stanley Kubrick’s *2001: A Space Odyssey* abandoned invasion entirely in favour of cosmic mystery. The alien presence remained largely unseen, manifesting through monoliths that accelerated evolution and nudged humanity toward an unknowable future.

But few filmmakers embraced a sense of unbridled wonder with the unknown more completely than Spielberg. When *Close Encounters of the Third Kind* was released in 1977, it effectively rewrote the very grammar of alien cinema. Richard

Dreyfuss’ Roy Neary abandons his job, his family, and eventually his place in ordinary society because a brief glimpse of something impossible has broken his ability to care about anything else. When contact finally occurs at Devil’s Tower, Spielberg and composer John Williams turn the climax into a strangely moving duet between a synthesiser and a spacecraft with a simple five-note melody.

That idea reached its fullest expression through Carl Sagan’s *Contact* and Denis Villeneuve’s *Arrival*. Both recognised that contact begins with communication. Jodie Foster’s Ellie Arroway discovers a coded transmission from beyond and spends the film navigating politicians, engineers, and sceptics. Nearly two decades later, *Arrival* reduced first contact to language lessons inside a mist-filled spacecraft, where Amy Adams’ Louise Banks tests the Sapir-Whorf hypothesis against heptapod visitors whose language reshapes her perception. *Project Hail Mary* reached much the same conclusion this year, treating communication as the foundation of an unlikely interstellar friendship and punctuating that first exchange with a wink to John Williams’ iconic five-note *Close Encounters* motif.

First contact has also proven fertile ground for traditional UFO folklore and urban legends. M. Night Shyamalan’s *Signs* draws heavily from crop-circle paranoia, filtering a global invasion through the anxieties of a grieving Pennsylvania family. Andrew Patterson’s *The Vast of Night* recreates the world of 1950s switchboard operators and amateur radio enthusiasts in a small town. And Egor Abramenko’s *Sputnik* channels a different strain of extraterrestrial mythology, embedding its creature within the secrecy of the Soviet military apparatus and the long tradition of state cover-ups that has accompanied UFO culture on both sides of the Iron Curtain.

Contrary to the *Independence Day* school of thought, alien invasions do not always occur within comfortable driving distance of Washington, D.C. – the genre’s most fascinating variations often emerged beyond Hollywood.

Andrei Tarkovsky’s *Solaris* depicted first contact as a confrontation with memory and grief, while Kiyoshi Kurosawa’s *Before We Vanish* imagined invasion through the theft of human concepts themselves. Neill Blomkamp’s *District 9* even relocated extraterrestrials into Johannesburg and framed them through the legacy of apartheid. And though it falls outside cinema, any discussion of modern first-contact fiction would feel incomplete without Cixin Liu’s *The Three-Body Problem*, whose influential Dark Forest hypothesis argues that silence may be the universe’s dominant survival strategy.

This holistic evolution helps explain why first-contact stories keep finding new life – every era tends to imagine the alien through its own dominant preoccupations. For over a century, science fiction has repeatedly asked what happens when humanity encounters something radically unfamiliar. Though the answers have varied according to circumstance, technology, politics, and culture, the question still persists.

Which brings us back to Spielberg. Details surrounding *Disclosure Day* still remain guarded, but its premise appears to revolve around the public confirmation of extraterrestrial life and the social aftershocks that follow. If the film succeeds, it will serve as a record of an era increasingly convinced that the unknown may already be here, even if the search for intelligent life elsewhere has repeatedly yielded uncomfortable findings much closer to home. Perhaps the truth was never really out there after all.

THE DAILY QUIZ

Here is a quiz to test your FIFA World Cup knowledge

N. Soorya Prakash

- QUESTION 1**
Which Goalkeeper holds the record for most consecutive clean sheets and as well as most consecutive minutes without conceding a goal in World Cup history?
- QUESTION 2**
Which Manager holds the record of having won the most tournaments in World Cup history?
- QUESTION 3**
Who is the only player to have won 4 medals in the World Cup history?
- QUESTION 4**
Which player has the distinction of having scored at least one goal in all five tournaments that he played?
- QUESTION 5**
Which was the first World Cup to be held outside Europe and the Americas, and who hosted it?



Visual Question:
Identify the player and what is the unique record that he possesses in World Cup history? THE HINDU ARCHIVES

- Questions and Answers to the previous day’s daily quiz:**
1. Name his debut film made in 1977 that had Kamal Hasan, Rajinikanth and Sridevi and is considered an all-time classic in Indian cinema. **Ans: 16 Vayathinile**
2. What was the moniker given to him as a tribute to his directorial prowess and with what words (on screen) did he welcome the viewers of his films? **Ans: Iyakkunar Imayam (Pinnacle among Directors) and Yen Iniya Tamil Makkale**
3. The first of his six National awards was for the Telugu film ‘Seethakoka Chiluka’. Of which Tamil work that introduced Karthik and Radha was it a remake? **Ans: Alaigal Oivathillai**
4. Bharathiraja also dabbled in acting and in ‘Rettaisuzhi,’ he shared screen space with another

- legendary filmmaker. Name him. **Ans: K. Balachander**
5. Known for introducing many a talent, which film of his saw the debut of the award-winning lyricist Vairamuthu? **Ans: Nizhalgal**
6. ‘Aakhree Raasta’, the hit Amitabh Bachchan-starrer, was the Hindi remake of which Bharathiraja film? **Ans: Oru Kaidhiyin Diary**
7. Who were the music directors for his National Award-winning films ‘Vedham Pudhithu’ and ‘Karuthamma’? **Ans: Devendran and A.R. Rahman**
- Visual: Name this Bharathiraja film, the only one he made with the thespian Sivaji Ganesan, said to have been inspired by writer Fyodor Dostoevsky’s love life. **Ans: Muthal Mariyathai**
- Early Birds:** Abhay Krishan | Amit Kumar | Pankaj Gharde | Bhavya Pandey | Santhiya Lakshmi



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

“Good grief! This article is full of mistakes. The author has spelt the word ‘opposite’ with an ‘a’! How could...”

“....it isn’t a mistake. The word ‘apposite’ does exist.”

“It does?”

“Yes, it does. The ‘a’ in the first syllable is like the ‘a’ in ‘act’, ‘fact’ and ‘tact’. The ‘o’ in the second syllable is like the ‘a’ in ‘China’ and ‘amount’. The final syllable is like...”

“...is like the final syllable in ‘opposite’, I suppose?”

“You suppose right. Apposite means appropriate or suitable. It is a word usually used in formal contexts. For example, I can say, some of the objections made by the members of the Board were apposite.”

“The Minister’s remarks were not apposite to the discussion.”

“Politicians seldom make apposite remarks.”

“That’s true. What happened in yesterday’s final? Did your team win?”

“No, we didn’t. Sujatha and Ramesh blamed themselves for the loss.”

“I don’t believe it. Sujatha usually blames the others. Do you mean to say she has changed?”

“Of course, not. She blamed Ramesh for our team’s defeat.”

“Well, in that case, Sujatha and Ramesh did not blame themselves.”

“Yes, they did. Sujatha blamed Ramesh and Ramesh blamed Sujatha.”

“If that is the case, they didn’t blame themselves; they blamed each other.”

“They blamed each other?”

“...when you say ‘Sujatha and Ramesh blamed themselves’, it means that Sujatha blamed herself and Ramesh blamed himself.”

“I see. In other words, Sujatha felt that she was responsible for her team’s defeat. She didn’t think it was Ramesh’s fault that the team lost.”

“Exactly! And Ramesh feels the same way too. He, like Sujatha, believes that it was he who let the team down. Each one takes the blame.”

“But when you say that they blamed each other, then...”

“....when you say, Sujatha and Ramesh blamed each other, it means that Sujatha blamed Ramesh for the defeat and”

“....Ramesh blamed Sujatha!”

“Exactly! Sounds more like the Ramesh and Sujatha we know, doesn’t it?”

“It certainly does. In our country, political parties, instead of blaming themselves for the mess the country is in, blame one another.”

“Politicians are always looking for a scapegoat.”

“Right now, the scapegoat seems to be the country.”

“Sad, but true. By the way, I need your help. Do you think...”

“....oh, I don’t know. I am not...”

“....I will make you an offer that you can’t refuse.”

“Make me an offer that I can’t refuse, eh? You watched Godfather during the weekend, did you?”

“That’s right. It was great. I saw...”

“...yes, it was. Could you explain me why the third son...?”

“Could you explain to me why. The word ‘explain’ is usually followed by ‘to’.”

“I explained to him why it was not possible.”

“I explained to my boss why his plans could not be carried out.”

“I am sure he was really happy to know that! It must have made his day.”

“Very funny”

Published in *The Hindu* on December 12, 2000

Word of the day

Perforce:
by necessity; by force of circumstance

Synonyms: inevitably, necessarily, needs, unavoidably

Usage: *The road was blocked, so we perforce took another route.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/perforce

International Phonetic Alphabet: /pəfɔːs/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Text & Context’

From Page One

Trump backs off from Iran strikes; deal likely

Mr. Trump's threats, Iran's counter-threats, his abrupt U-turn and claims of progress in talks all came within hours, following another round of U.S. air strikes on Iran and Tehran's retaliation against U.S. bases in the region.

U.S. Central Command (CENTCOM) said its forces launched strikes on Iranian military surveillance capabilities, communication systems, and air defence sites across Iran in the early hours of Thursday (local time).

"U.S. Marine Corps, Air Force, and Navy assets fired precision munitions on Iranian targets that posed a threat to U.S. forces and international commercial ships transiting regional waters," the CENTCOM said in a statement, adding that the attacks were "in response to Iran's unwarranted and continued aggression".

Iranian state media confirmed that Hormozgan and other southern regions were attacked by the U.S. In response, Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) launched two waves of strikes targeting American military bases in three countries in the region, the Guards said.

"Eighteen key targets belonging to the criminal U.S. military were struck and destroyed at the Ali al-Salem and Ahmad al-Jaber airbases in Kuwait, as well as the Sheikh Isa airbase in Bahrain," the IRGC said.

Homemakers build nation: Supreme Court

The top court also noted the need to shift from the stereotypical terminology of daily usage from "housewife" to "homemaker".

Recognising all aspects of being a homemaker and the unpaid labour that a homemaker undertakes, the court directed the Motor Accidents Claim Tribunal (MACT) to award a separate compensation of ₹30,000 per month under the head of "domestic care" in cases involving death of a homemaker. It clarified that this amount would be treated as the minimum value of a homemaker's unpaid work and would increase by 10% every three years. If the homemaker also had a paid job, this amount would be awarded in addition to her income.

However, the court resorted to the application of homemaker to the traditional image of woman. The court said, "...for the purposes of the present case and more particularly the quantification of domestic efforts, we limit its application to the quintessential and traditional image, that of a woman."

SC stays Allahabad HC's 'adverse' order against IAS officer

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday stayed an Allahabad High Court order containing adverse remarks against senior IAS officer Sanjay Prasad, Additional Chief Secretary to the Uttar Pradesh government, and directing the Department of Personnel and Training to examine his suitability for future assignments by the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet.

A Bench of Justices Prashant Kumar Mishra and Atul S. Chandurkar passed the interim order while issuing notice on a plea filed by Mr. Prasad challenging the findings and directions issued by the HC in its June 3 ruling.

'Issue notice'

"Issue notice, returnable in 10 weeks. In the meanwhile, directions issued by the High Court under the impugned order shall remain stayed," the Bench said.

The High Court was hearing a *habeas corpus* petition filed by Jhansi resident Megha Raikwar seeking the recovery of her 15-year-old daughter from the alleged illegal custody of the respondent. During the proceedings, the court was informed that an FIR had been registered and a chargesheet filed. Ms. Raikwar, however, contended that the investigation had failed to identify the "real" accused and that the chargesheet was filed largely on

the basis of statements made by the accused.

The High Court subsequently found that the chargesheet had not been filed in compliance with the directions issued in its judgment in *Subhash Chandra & Others v. State of Uttar Pradesh*, which laid down detailed guidelines to ensure that criminal investigations are fair and legally sustainable. It therefore called for an explanation from the Home Department.

In its affidavit, the State government informed the HC that it intended to challenge the *Subhash Chandra* judgment before the Supreme Court and requested that no further adverse orders be passed until the proposed appeal was filed. The court accordingly deferred the matter and awaited an update on the proposed challenge. However, despite the passage of more than three months since the affidavit was filed and over a year since the *Subhash Chandra* judgment was delivered, the State had yet to approach the Supreme Court.

Taking exception to the delay, Justice Vinod Diwaker observed that the proposed appeal was being used to justify inaction on the implementation of the court's directions.

In its order, the HC observed that "unbridled" and "unchecked" discretion vested in civil servants undermines the rule of law and weakens accountability in public administration.

Two killed as violence flares up in Manipur; NPF office stormed

Unidentified gunmen kill a Kuki man and woman in Kamjong district's Kuluth village close to the Myanmar border; mob storms Naga People's Front office in Senapati over deaths of six Nagas, sets furniture and other properties on fire

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Unidentified gunmen killed a Kuki man and a woman at a village in Kamjong district in Manipur early in the morning on Thursday after violence broke out in Senapati district over the alleged killing of six Nagas taken hostage on May 13.

Both districts are Naga-dominated.

Officials in the State's capital, Imphal, confirmed the death of two persons at Kamjong district's Kuluth village near the India-Myanmar border. At least two others were reported injured.

The Eastern Kuki Chiefs' Association said the attackers belonged to an armed Naga group.

"The attackers mercilessly set fire to seven houses,



Bodies, suspected to be of six Naga persons abducted on May 13, being brought to a mortuary in Imphal on Thursday . PTI

including the village church, causing extensive destruction to both private property and a sacred place of worship," it said in a statement.

On the other hand, the Eastern Command Naga Village Guard blamed the attack on an armed Kuki group in conflict with another Kuki extremist group over area domination along the International Border. The Naga organisation claimed that one of the Kuki groups was Myanmar-based.

On Wednesday night, a mob stormed the office of the Naga People's Front (NPF) in Senapati town,

and set its furniture and other properties on fire.

The NPF, a Nagaland-headquartered party, is an ally of the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in Manipur. The regional party has five MLAs in the 60-member Manipur Assembly.

The mob vented its ire on the NPF office after the security forces recovered the bodies of six Liangmai Nagas, allegedly abducted by Kuki extremists after three Thadou tribal church leaders were gunned down in Kangpokpi district on May 13.

One of the reasons behind the storming of the NPF office was the perception that the party's key leader and Nagaland Chief Minister Neiphiu Rio played a key role in the release of 14 Kuki hostages by Nagas on Tuesday, without securing the release of the

six Nagas held captive by the Kukis.

The mortal remains of the six Nagas were recovered on Wednesday after nearly 24 hours of sustained search operations involving about 450 personnel of the Manipur Police, Central Reserve Police Force, and Assam Rifles.

24-hour shutdown

The United Naga Council called a 24-hour shutdown to protest the alleged killing of the six Naga men. The shutdown affected normal life in the Naga-inhabited areas on Thursday.

In Meitei-dominated Imphal, hundreds of protesters gathered outside the Jawaharlal Nehru Institute of Medical Sciences after the mortal remains of the six Nagas were taken there for post-mortem on Wednesday night.

J&K CM raises Statehood demand with PM Modi

The Hindu Bureau
SRINAGAR

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah raised the issue of Statehood with Prime Minister Narendra Modi at a meeting in Delhi on Thursday.

The National Conference (NC) plans to hold a protest in Delhi on the first day of the upcoming Monsoon Session of Parliament to press for the restoration of Statehood for J&K. Mr. Abdullah, in a post on X, said he called on Mr. Modi in Delhi "to discuss issues of importance to J&K, including the early return of Statehood, the state of the economy, pace of development, and promotion of tourism". NC president Farooq Abdullah, while speaking in Srinagar, said the party's constitutional struggle for the restoration of Statehood and rights will continue. He said all J&K's political parties were united on this demand.

France backs 'Make in India' in defence, signals new model for Rafale deal

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

Ahead of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to France for the G7 Summit, French diplomatic sources on Thursday said the nation's future defence cooperation with India, including the proposed Rafale fighter jet deal, will be aligned with the 'Make in India' initiative and based on an equal partnership.

France has reiterated its commitment to India's 'Make in India' programme in the defence sector, signalling that the proposed procurement of 114 Rafale fighter jets for the Indian Air Force (IAF) would be structured differently from previous defence deals.

During the visit on June 13-14, Mr. Modi is scheduled to hold bilateral talks with French President Emmanuel Macron on the sidelines of the summit.

India is currently advancing a mega defence acquisition programme, estimated at around ₹3.25 lakh crore, for 114 Rafale fighter aircraft from the IAF.

According to French diplomatic sources, the proposed collaboration is being envisioned as a partnership based on co-development and industrial cooperation rather than a traditional client-vendor arrangement.

"The defence programmes developed jointly by France will be fully aligned with India's 'Make in India' requirements," a source said. The sources stressed that the partnership was based on an "equal-to-equal" approach.

Civil nuclear energy is expected to feature prominently in discussions between Mr. Macron and Mr. Modi. French officials expressed optimism about the prospects of enhanced cooperation in the nuclear sector, citing recent legislative reforms in India.



Narendra Modi will hold bilateral talks with French President Emmanuel Macron on the sidelines of the G7 Summit. FILE PHOTO

One year since AI-171 crash, pilot body questions delay in release of final report

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

On the first anniversary of Air India flight AI-171 crash in Ahmedabad, the Federation of Indian Pilots has questioned the delay in releasing the final investigation report. It urged authorities not to publish an incomplete interim report, warning that it could add to confusion and speculation on the cause of the accident.

"We are at one year since the crash. Why is the AAIB [Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau] unable to investigate a flight of 32 seconds," the federation's president C.S. Randhawa asked at a press conference in Ahmedabad.

The June 2025 incident claimed 261 lives – 242 onboard and 19 on the ground.

A preliminary investigation report found that the aircraft's fuel control switches had moved to the cut-off position, interrupting fuel supply to the engines moments before the crash. While the report stopped short of determining whether the switch movement was the result of a deliberate action or inadvertently done or a technical malfunction, it included a brief cockpit exchange between the plane's two pilots that has triggered widespread speculation on the cause of the accident.

Pilot associations have condemned the inclusion of the excerpt, arguing that it has contributed to the building of a narrative around pilot involvement before the investigation reached a definitive conclusion.

On Thursday, Mr. Randhawa warned that an incomplete, interim report could cause more confusion. "If there are no conclusive findings, we have asked the government to wait until the probe is concluded and publish the final report," he added.

Analysis under way

Government officials said an interim report on the Air India AI-171 crash would be released soon. They added that analysis of data from the aircraft's engines, manufactured by U.S.-based General Electric, was still under way at the manufacturer's facilities in the U.S., contributing to the delay in releasing the final report.



Captain C.S. Randhawa

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Delhi HC quashes FIR, ED money laundering case against Newsclick

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court has quashed a first information report (FIR) registered against the digital news platform Newsclick and its founder Prabir Purkayastha, holding that the allegations relating to foreign direct investment (FDI), share valuation and expenditure of funds did not disclose offences of cheating or criminal breach of trust.

In a judgment delivered on May 29, Justice Neena Bansal Krishna quashed the FIR registered by the Economic Offences Wing on August 26, 2020, observing that even if all allegations in the complaint were accepted at face value, essential ingredients of the offences were not made out.

The court quashed the Enforcement Directorate's ECIR registered on September 2, 2020, under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), noting that the money laundering



Prabir Purkayastha

case was founded on the same allegations forming the basis of the FIR.

'Overvaluing shares'

The Delhi Police's FIR alleged that PPK Newsclick Studio Private Ltd. received FDI of ₹9.59 crore from Worldwide Media Holdings LLC, the U.S., during the financial year 2018-19 in exchange of 7.69% shares of the company. The FIR said the investment was made by overvaluing the shares of the petitioner company to avoid the alleged cap of 26% FDI in a digital news website. It alleged that over

45% of this investment was diverted or siphoned off towards the payment of salary/consultancy fees, rent, and other expenses, which were alleged to have been made for ulterior motives. The ED initiated its probe on the basis of the police FIR. The court, however, noted that at the time the investment was made, there was no cap on FDI in digital news media.

The court further stated that FEMA regulations required shares issued to foreign investors to be priced at not less than their fair value and that the fair value of the equity shares had been determined by an independent valuer as ₹9,188 per share.

It said the eventual issue price of ₹11,510 per share to Worldwide Media was the result of negotiations between the investor and the company. "It is an economic decision which does not spell out any criminal offence," the judge said.

The petitioners have been charged with the offence under Section 420 IPC which deals with cheating and dishonestly inducing delivery of property.

Allegations of cheating

Justice Krishna remarked that for the offence of cheating, it is necessary that there must be an aggrieved person who has been cheated of his valuable property. It said there was no complaint by Worldwide Media about having been cheated by Newsclick.

"Pertinently, the complaint had been made by one Shoban Singh, who was merely an informant and was not the aggrieved person," it said.

Similarly, the court found that the offence of criminal breach of trust under Section 406 IPC was absent because there was no entrustment of property that could have been misappropriated. The transaction was merely one of investment and purchase of shares, it said.

NC, BJP slam Pakistan's hand in PoK violence, seek UN intervention

The Hindu Bureau
SRINAGAR

Leaders of the National Conference (NC) and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Thursday condemned Pakistan's actions in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK), with NC president Farooq Abdullah demanding a probe by the United Nations into the incidents of atrocities.

"Jammu and Kashmir is witnessing troubling times. People of the part of J&K that is under Pakistan are facing oppression and atrocities. Several people have been martyred," Mr. Abdullah said.

Condemning the civilian killings during the recent unrest in PoK, BJP general secretary Ashok Kaul said the Pakistan Army was committing "atrocities on the civilians". "Around 30 civilians have died in the firing. Civilians were fired upon like the Jallianwala Bagh incident. The BJP stands by the 1994 Parliament resolution that PoK was part of J&K," he said.



APPEAL

Master **Somnath Rajbanshi**, Manipal Hospital No.MH018473384, 14 months has been Diagnosed to be Suffering from Congenital Heart Disease, Moderate PM VSD, Dilated LA and LV. He requires to undergo VSD surgical closure. The Estimated cost of the Surgery is Rs.4,00,000/-.

Please send donation however small by Cheque/D.D./M.O Fav. **Save Poor Lives A/c Somnath Rajbanshi, Our A/c Details:** S/B A/c No. 20000913487. S.B.I. R.A.Puram, IFSC CODE:SBIN001855. Please Donate by G-pay No.9884607377, UPI Id: savepoorlives@oksb. Donations are exempted under 80G of I.T.ACT.

SAVE POOR LIVES, Flat No. A1, Ceebros Garden, Door No.14/76, Kamarajar Salai, Raja Annamalaiapuram, Chennai-600028. Ph. No. 044 42044165 / 9884607377. Email: savepoorlives@gmail.com. Our website: www.savepoorlives.com



HC questions Speaker's move making Ritabrata LoP

The Hindu Bureau
KOLKATA

The Calcutta High Court on Thursday questioned the Speaker's decision to recognise expelled Trinamool Congress MLA Ritabrata Banerjee as the Leader of the Opposition (LoP) of the West Bengal Assembly without the consent of the political party.

While hearing a plea filed by the Trinamool against Speaker Rathindra Bose's move to accept a group of 59 rebel MLAs' proposal to recognise Mr. Ritabrata as the LoP instead of Sobhandeb Chattopadhyay, a single-judge Bench of the court asked the State, "The person, who was appointed as the LoP, doesn't belong to any party. He was expelled. Can the Speaker recognise a rebel leader as the LoP without the consent of a political party?"

In response, the State, represented by Additional Advocate-General Bilwadal Bhattacharya, sought time to file an affidavit. The court scheduled the next hearing for June 16.

Cong. to mount legal, political battle over rejection of Rajya Sabha papers

Party calls the issue a case of 'seat chori' by the BJP-EC, jugalbandi; the party plans a nation-wide agitation on inflation, unemployment, NEET paper leak, CBSE OSM row, and other issues; protest campaign likely to begin by the end of June

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Thursday said it would challenge the rejection of its Madhya Pradesh candidate Mee-nakshi Natarajan's nomination for the Rajya Sabha election legally and politically. It also announced a nationwide campaign on issues such as inflation, unemployment, the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test-Undergraduate (NE ET-UG) and other paper leaks, and the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) On-Screen Marking (OSM) controversy.

The decision was taken at a meeting of the party's top leadership, presided over by Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge and attended by Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, party general secretaries K.C. Venugopal, Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, and Jairam Ramesh and other leaders. In a post



Protest rite: Congress workers perform 'Sadbuddhi Yagya' in Bikaner over the Rajya Sabha nomination controversy, ANI

on X, Mr. Gandhi called the candidacy issue a case of seat chori [theft] and said that it is easier to fix elections with the help of the Election Commission rather than win them. "After vote Chori and Sarkar Chori – the BJP-EC jugalbandi [tie-up] has finished the contest before it has even begun with Seat Chori."

'Differential treatment' "Congress candidate Mee-nakshi Natarajanji submitted every document. No pending cases. The EC can-

celled her nomination on a frivolous BJP objection. Parimal Nathwaniji, the BJP-backed Independent, got his own name wrong on the form and skipped multiple mandatory disclosures. The EC gave him an extension to fix everything," he said. The Opposition leader added that the same EC treated two candidates very differently.

"One was disqualified without even a hearing. The other was rewarded despite not following the rules," Mr. Gandhi said.

Soon, the 60-odd Congress MLAs from Madhya Pradesh are likely to launch a protest against the decision of the Returning Officer in New Delhi.

In a post on X, Mr. Kharge said the country was facing serious challenges, including inflation, unemployment, examination scandals and social inequality. "Paper leaks in NEET and various recruitment exams, along with controversies related to the education system, have shaken the trust of millions of youth and their families..." he said.

New campaign in talks "Today, unfortunately, we see that those institutions and systems which took decades to build are being deliberately weakened. Therefore, our responsibility is not only toward political struggle, but also toward safeguarding India's Constitution, democracy, and social justice," Mr. Kharge said.

The party has drawn up

a list of issues which would be highlighted in a three-four-month-long campaign. Though the exact modalities are being worked out, the campaign is expected to start by the end of June.

Mr. Gandhi is said to have urged his colleagues to stand with the people, telling them that price rise, fuel shortage, paper leaks are because of "wrong policies" of the Prime Minister. Ms. Vadra reportedly said the party should focus on a targeted campaign.

Addressing a press conference with Mr. Ramesh after the nearly three-hour meeting, Mr. Venugopal described recent developments in Madhya Pradesh and Jharkhand as a matter of "great worry".

Calling the Madhya Pradesh episode "seat chori", he said the developments reflected the "pathetic condition of Indian democracy". "Today's meeting discussed the matter in detail. We will fight this politically and legally," he said.

Loyalist Kalyan hits out at Abhishek, calls him 'arrogant'

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

Trinamool Congress MP and senior leader Kalyan Banerjee lashed out at party general secretary Abhishek Banerjee on Thursday, calling him "arrogant". He also gave an ultimatum to Trinamool supremo Mamata Banerjee, asking her to choose between him and Mr. Abhishek. His remarks came amid the escalating crisis in the party.

A senior advocate, Mr. Kalyan said he would remove himself from all legal matters involving Mr. Abhishek. Mr. Kalyan was representing the Diamond Harbour MP at the Calcutta High Court in the signature forgery case.

"Henceforth, I will not be appearing in any matter for Abhishek Banerjee. I do not like this arrogant attitude. One must respect their seniors, I have 45 years of experience in this profession... How can he insult me," Mr. Kalyan asked after giving up Mr. Abhishek's case.

He also said that another legal counsel of Mr. Abhishek had filed a separate writ petition on the same issue and that he was taken aback by the development. He said had he known



Kalyan Banerjee

about the new case, he would not have brought it before the judge, as two Benches cannot hear the same matter. He also alleged that the new case was filed after instructions "from the top".

"He [Mr. Abhishek] must understand that because of him we have lost the elections. But he will go around disrespecting everyone," Mr. Kalyan said.

However, Mr. Kalyan added that he would continue to appear for cases and legal matters related to the party. The Sreerampur MP said if Ms. Mamata chose to side with her nephew, then she would have to let him go. "If you let go of Abhishek Banerjee, then I am there. He destroyed the party," Mr. Kalyan said.

The leader has, so far, been a staunch loyalist of Ms. Mamata.

Fresh setback for Trinamool as another RS member quits

The Hindu Bureau
KOLKATA

In another jolt to the Trinamool Congress, a third Rajya Sabha member, Prakash Chik Barik, resigned from the Upper House and the party on Thursday.

Mr. Barik, who was a Minister in the Cabinet of former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee, submitted his resignation letter to Vice-President C.P. Radhakrishnan.

However, he did not specify any reason for the decision.

"People have favoured the BJP over the Trinamool... I have resigned in view of the people's mandate... I have not spoken to Mamata Banerjee as of now. I will work as per Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari's instructions in the future. I will work for development," said Mr. Barik after the resignation, while sitting at the official residence of BJP MP for Jharkhand's Godda, Nishikant Dubey, at Safdarjung in Delhi.

Sukhendu Sekhar Roy and Sushmita Dev, MPs, resigned on Monday and Wednesday, respectively.

With Mr. Barik's resignation, the Trinamool's strength in the Rajya Sabha is set to fall to 10 MPs from the earlier 13.

Mamata stood by me; now it's my duty to stand by her: MP

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Two Trinamool Congress Lok Sabha members – Shatrughan Sinha and Pratima Mondol – have publicly reaffirmed their loyalty to party founder and president Mamata Banerjee, putting to rest talk of defection.

An Actor-turned-politician, Mr. Sinha, who represents Asansol, joined the Trinamool in 2022, after quitting the BJP and a short stint in the Congress. He said Ms. Banerjee stood by him during a difficult time.

"Today, in her difficult phase, I cannot abandon her," he said.

Mr. Sinha, who is a multi-talented MP from Bihar, contested the bypoll from the Asansol Lok Sabha constituency in 2022. "I first came to Asansol at Didi's [Mamata's] invitation. In my very first election there, I won by a record margin. I also won a second time by a significant margin," he said.

"After I lost the Patna election in 2019, I was in a difficult situation and very few people came to my aid. Mamata Banerjee was among the few who supported and encouraged me," Mr. Sinha said.

He rejected speculation



Shatrughan Sinha

Amid defection rumours, Shatrughan Sinha and Pratima Mondol reaffirms their loyalty to the Trinamool supremo

that he had joined the rebels. "I was elected on the Trinamool Congress symbol – the Jora Phool – not once but twice, with the blessings of God. My principle is very clear: Mamata ji stood by me, it is now my duty to stand by her in this moment as well," he added.

Ms. Mondol, a three-time MP for Jaynagar, a reserved constituency, distanced herself from the rebel group.

"I have not signed any papers. I am not part of that group. I do not know why they are using my name," she said.

No room for divisive politics in party: Sunetra

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

NCP president and Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Sunetra Pawar on Thursday told party cadres that she will not tolerate undue interferences and will take tough decisions like her husband Ajit Pawar. She also said that her party will not support divisive politics.

Ms. Pawar was speaking at the 27th foundation day of the Nationalist Congress Party at Mumbai's Shanmukhananda hall.

"It is our commitment that all sections of the society should feel secure. May it be tribals, backward classes, minorities or OBCs. All the communities should stay together. There is no place in the party for divisive politics," she said. The party remained committed to create a harmonious social environment, Ms. Pawar said.

Issuing a warning to party workers against unruly and indisciplined behaviour, she said it was everyone's responsibility to maintain the party's image.

The NCP chief's statements assume significance in the backdrop of the recent open public criticism of the party by disgruntled elements.



Angry youth: Cockroach Janta Party supporters participate in the protest at Savitribai Phule Pune University on Thursday. PTI

At Pune protest, CJP unveils manifesto on examination reforms

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) on Thursday staged a protest at the Ambedkar statue at Savitribai Phule Pune University (SPPU) in Pune, releasing a five-point manifesto recommending reforms in the examination process across the country.

The CJP, which began with a satirical social media post in response to a critical remark by the Chief Justice of India last month, is fast evolving into a mass movement of youth focused on grievances with the examination system and demanding the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke presented the movement's manifesto, which demanded compensation of ₹10,000 per candidate in the event of a paper leak to cover preparation and travel expenses; declaration of results within one month of an exam; advance announcement of back-up dates whenever an exam is cancelled to reduce mental stress on students; physical evaluation of answer sheets instead of assessments based on digital scans; a guarantee that exam delays will not affect candidates due to age limits nor reduce their num-

ber of attempts; and an independent body to audit examination tenders.

Indefinite protest soon "If they are not ready for simple resignation and admit the mistake, then how can we expect them to fix the education system. It starts with admitting a mistake," Mr. Dipke said.

Announcing he would start an indefinite protest in Delhi on June 20, he appealed to students to join him.

Mr. Dipke and other CJP supporters also plan to campaign across the country to create credibility for their assurance that "this movement can do something". He said, "It has been just 15 days, give us time to decide on the course of action. If you have given 12 years of time to people in power, give us at least 12 weeks."

"The government must take accountability for their mistakes for which students are paying the cost," said Ladakhi activist Sonam Wangchuk who participated in the protest. Several other activists, including Asim Sarode, also extended their support during the SPPU agitation, raising slogans such as 'Zimmedari leni hogi (Responsibility must be taken)' and 'I am cockroach'.

OFFICE OF EXECUTIVE ENGINEER, M&H, Div.-II, Jaipur
No 435
Date : 02/06/2026
Notice Inviting Bid No.05/2026-27
Bids for 01 (One Nos.) Work are invited from interested bidders upto 06:00 PM dated 24.06.2026 Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in, http://sppp.raj.nic.in) of the state and M&H departmental website. The approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 500.00 Lacs.
UBN No: MHS2627WSRC01400
Executive Engineer
M&H, Div.-II, Jaipur
DIPR/C/9986/26

OFFICE OF THE ADDL. CHIEF ENGINEER
PWD ZONE-II JODHPUR (HQ-BARMER)
No. 730
Date 05.06.2026
Notice Inviting Bid No. 01/2026-27
NIB- PWD2627A0940
Bid for Civil Works (Road and Building) are invited from interested bidders upto Date 29.06.2026, 06.00 PM Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in and http://sppp.raj.nic.in) of the Rajasthan and the state. The approximate value procurement is Rs. 5533.00 Lac.
UBN No.
1. PWD2627WLOB04068 2. PWD2627WLOB04071 3. PWD2627WLOB04074
4. PWD2627WLOB04077
Addl. Chief Engineer
PWD Zone-II Jodhpur(HQ-Barmer)
DIPR/C/10118/2026

PUNJAB STATE WAREHOUSING CORPORATION
SCO 74-75, BANK SQUARE, SECTOR-178 CHANDIGARH
PBX: 0172-5197847, 5197846
NOTICE INVITING TENDER
PSWC invites online tenders through GeM Portal for creation of 3.75 LMT godown capacities at 09 locations in the State of Punjab for guaranteed lease of 10 years on Build, Own and Operate/Lease basis for storage requirements of FCI under two bid system 'Technical Bid' and 'Financial Bid'.
NIT (alongwith GeM Bid IDs) is available on Department's website i.e. https://pswc.in
PSWC reserves the right to scrap the tender at any stage without assigning any reason and PSWC will not be held liable for any costs and consequences incurred by the intending bidders.
Note: Any corrigendum(s)/Notification(s) to this Notice Inviting E-Tender shall be published Department's website & GeM Portal.
1004/12/2026-27/12240
Managing Director, PSWC

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER, P.W.D.,
CIRCLE-JHALAWAR
Room No. - 158, Ground Floor (Public Works Department), Mini Secretariat, Jhalawar
E-mail - piw_jhalawar@rediffmail.com/sejwar.pwd@rajasthan.gov.in
Phone No. - 07432-233336
S. No. - 234
Date - 04.06.2026
NIT No.09/2026-27
Notice Inviting Bid
NIB No. PWD2627A0920
Bids for Const. of Road from Lasudiya shah to Gokulpura & 21 Nos. ML Roads in Jhalrapatan Constituency Distt. Jhalawar are invited from interested bidders upto 6.00 PM, Dated 01.07.2026 Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (http://erproc.rajasthan.gov.in, http://sppp.raj.nic.in) of the Rajasthan and http://pwd.rajasthan.gov.in website. The approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 2304.76 Lacs.
S. No. UBN No. S. No. UBN No. S. No. UBN No.
1 PWD2627WSOB03959 2 PWD2627WSOB03960 3 PWD2627WSOB03961
4 PWD2627WSOB03963 5 PWD2627WSOB03966 6 PWD2627WSOB03967
7 PWD2627WSOB03968 8 PWD2627WSOB03970 9 PWD2627WSOB03971
10 PWD2627WSOB03972 11 PWD2627WSOB03973 12 PWD2627WSOB03974
13 PWD2627WSOB03976 14 PWD2627WSOB03978 15 PWD2627WSOB03981
(Mukesh Chand Meena)
Superintending Engineer
Public Works Department
Circle-Jhalawar
DIPR/C/10067/2026

MAHATRANSCO
Maharashtra State Electricity Transmission Co. Ltd.
Tenders are invited through e-Tendering in SRM Two Bid system from the registered vendors for Supply of following:
Tender No. & Description of Material Estimated Amount (in Rs. Lakhs) Due Date & Time (Hrs.) for Submission & Opening of Tender
SP/T-12/0626_TKC1
RFx 7000040254 (1st Call) for Work of replacement of existing 0.2 ACSR Panther conductor by equivalent HPC (High Performance Conductor) along with suitable hardware, accessories and insulators for i) 132kV Dhule-Sakri Line and 132kV Shivajinagar- Sakri Line Ckt-I, ii) 132kV Pimperkhed-Chalisgaon ii) 132kV Malkapur- Juniper Solar (Tighre) iv) 132kV Manmad- Chalisgaon along with replacement of EHV equipments at associated substations under EHV PC O&M Zones, Nashik.
Rs. 11730.20 Lakhs (Incl. GST)
Rs. 9940.85 Lakhs (Excl. GST)
09.07.2026 18:00 Hrs
09.07.2026 18:05 Hrs
25,000.00+GST
Contact Person: Office of the Executive Engineer (TKC1)
CPA, C.O. MSETCL, 1st Floor, Prakashgad Building, Bandra (E), Mumbai. Tel. No.: 022-69852717
Email id: cecpa@mahatransco.in, secpa@mahatransco.in, eetkc1cpa@mahatransco.in, eepc@mahatransco.in
For further details visit our website https://srmetender.mahatransco.in/
Any further amendments/clarifications will be published on the MSETCL website www.mahatransco.in & https://srmetender.mahatransco.in/. Bidders are therefore requested to check these websites for further updates.
Sd/-
Executive Engineer (P&C)

MAHATRANSCO
Maharashtra State Electricity Transmission Co. Ltd.
Tenders are invited through e-Tendering in SRM Two Bid system from the registered vendors for Supply of following:
Tender No. & Description of Material Estimated Amount (in Rs. Lakhs) Due Date & Time (Hrs.) for Submission & Opening of Tender
SP/T-11/0626_TKC1
RFx 7000040238 (1st Call) for Work of replacement of existing 0.2 ACSR Panther conductor by equivalent HPC (High Performance Conductor) along with suitable hardware, accessories and insulators for i) 132kV Kekatnimbhora - Pahur Line, ii) 132kV Akole-Kombhane and iii) 132kV Manmad-Pimperkhed along with replacement of EHV equipments at associated substations under EHV PC O&M Zones, Nashik
Rs. 6653.55 Lakhs (Incl. GST)
Rs. 5638.60 Lakhs (Excl. GST)
09.07.2026 18:00 Hrs
09.07.2026 18:05 Hrs
25,000.00+GST
Contact Person: Office of the Executive Engineer (TKC1)
CPA, C.O. MSETCL, 1st Floor, Prakashgad Building, Bandra (E), Mumbai. Tel. No.: 022-69852717
Email id: cecpa@mahatransco.in, secpa@mahatransco.in, eetkc1cpa@mahatransco.in, eepc@mahatransco.in
For further details visit our website https://srmetender.mahatransco.in/
Any further amendments/clarifications will be published on the MSETCL website www.mahatransco.in & https://srmetender.mahatransco.in/. Bidders are therefore requested to check these websites for further updates.
Sd/-
Executive Engineer (P&C)

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER, P.W.D.,
CIRCLE-JHALAWAR
Room No. - 158, Ground Floor (Public Works Department), Mini Secretariat, Jhalawar
E-mail - piw_jhalawar@rediffmail.com/sejwar.pwd@rajasthan.gov.in
Phone No. - 07432-233336
S. No. - 234
Date - 04.06.2026
NIT No.09/2026-27
Notice Inviting Bid
NIB No. PWD2627A0920
Bids for Const. of Road from Lasudiya shah to Gokulpura & 21 Nos. ML Roads in Jhalrapatan Constituency Distt. Jhalawar are invited from interested bidders upto 6.00 PM, Dated 01.07.2026 Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (http://erproc.rajasthan.gov.in, http://sppp.raj.nic.in) of the Rajasthan and http://pwd.rajasthan.gov.in website. The approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 2304.76 Lacs.
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1 PWD2627WSOB03959 2 PWD2627WSOB03960 3 PWD2627WSOB03961
4 PWD2627WSOB03963 5 PWD2627WSOB03966 6 PWD2627WSOB03967
7 PWD2627WSOB03968 8 PWD2627WSOB03970 9 PWD2627WSOB03971
10 PWD2627WSOB03972 11 PWD2627WSOB03973 12 PWD2627WSOB03974
13 PWD2627WSOB03976 14 PWD2627WSOB03978 15 PWD2627WSOB03981
(Mukesh Chand Meena)
Superintending Engineer
Public Works Department
Circle-Jhalawar
DIPR/C/10067/2026

The Navy has successfully carried out a complex and high-risk operation to recover and safely dispose of an unexploded missile warhead from a crude oil tanker that was en route to Kochi after suffering damage off the coast of Oman. It said that the Marshall Islands-flagged tanker *MT Olympic Life*, sailing from Fujairah in the UAE to Kochi, reported an explosion in its hull on May 26. The vessel informed authorities about the presence of an unexploded ordnance onboard. Upon receiving information, the Navy launched a coordinated response. The recovered ordnance has since been transported to a secure facility.

those mentioned in the Constitution (Scheduled Castes) Order of 1950. Currently, only Dalits of Hindu, Buddhist, and Sikh faiths are entitled to a Scheduled Caste classification, unlike the Scheduled Tribe status, which does not have a religion criterion. The Commission was initially given a two-year deadline to finish its work and submit a report to the government. Since 2024, the Commission has been

Mr. Adhikary said he has shifted his base from West Bengal to Kanpur three days ago and joined work at C3iHub on Wednesday .

Referring to the objectives of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act, 2012 (POCSO Act), the court noted that the legislation proceeds on the foundational premise that a child who has allegedly suffered sexual abuse

4	9	6	7	3	2	1	8	5
3	5	7	9	8	1	6	4	2
2	1	8	6	4	5	7	9	3
8	6	4	1	2	3	5	7	9
1	3	9	5	7	6	4	2	8
7	2	5	8	9	4	3	6	1
5	8	2	3	6	7	9	1	4
9	7	3	4	1	8	2	5	6
6	4	1	2	5	9	8	3	7

When Pramadavara was revived, Ruru married her. From then on, Ruru decided that whenever he saw a snake, he would kill it. Once when Ruru was bathing in the river, he saw a harmless water snake and was about to kill it, when the snake said, "Why do you want to kill me? I have not harmed you." Ruru narrated how his wife had once been bitten by a snake. The water snake said, "Death of a person comes because of his or her actions. Moreover, why should you kill all snakes, when it was only one snake that bit her?" Ruru agreed to spare the snake's life, but wanted to know what it had done in its previous birth to be a snake now. The snake said, "In my previous birth, I was a rishi called Sahasrapathi. I tied some darbha grass to a stick, to make it resemble a snake. I threw it in the path of sage Khagame, just to frighten him. He fainted when he saw the snake, but when he realised it was a prank, he cursed me. He said I would be born a snake, but because I had only used a stick to frighten him, I would be a non-venomous snake. He said that when I saw Ruru, the descendant of Chyavana, I would be released from my curse. Now I have seen you, and so my curse has ended."

TOKEN OF APPRECIATION

New York temporarily renames streets after Pele and Henry



FILE PHOTO

New York has honoured two footballing greats by temporarily renaming streets after Pele and Thierry Henry. Crowd gathered at West 50th Street and 6th Avenue in Manhattan to mark the unveiling of “Thierry Henry Way” by city officials. The intersection of Shea Road and Meridian Road was renamed after Pele.

SETBACK

Morocco forced to make two changes to its WC contingent



GETTY IMAGES

Morocco has been hit by the loss of two starters to injury, with Nayef Aguerd and Abde Ezzalzouli, *in pic.*, replaced in its World Cup squad. Defender Marwane Saadane and striker Amine Sbai have been brought in. Morocco opens its Group C campaign against five-time champion Brazil at the New York New Jersey Stadium on Saturday.

ANXIOUS WAIT

Goalkeeper Verbruggen a doubt for the Dutch team’s first fixture



GETTY IMAGES

Netherlands goalkeeper Bart Verbruggen missed training on Wednesday, two days after hurting his hip in a collision during a warm-up match with Uzbekistan. It left his status in question for the team’s World Cup opener against Japan. Verbruggen is the first-choice custodian for head coach Ronald Koeman.

SECOND SPELL

Real Madrid names Mourinho as coach on a three-year deal



FILE PHOTO

Real Madrid named Jose Mourinho as its new head coach on a three-year deal until June 30, 2029, the 15-time European champion announced on Thursday. Mourinho will return to the club on July 13 to begin his second spell with Real for the start of pre-season training. His first stint in Madrid was from 2010-13.

Of old warhorses, their longevity and last dance

While Messi, Ronaldo and Ochoa are appearing in their record-equalling sixth tournament, Modric and Neuer are going strong in their 40s; they are, however, set to bow out soon

FIFA WORLD CUP

S. Shrivathsan

Look at age-verification documents would make one wonder how these war-horses’ batteries still have enough charge for the FIFA World Cup.

It appears as though they have been competing at football’s glitziest spectacle since time immemorial. The ageless fighters, however, are likely to bid adieu to the pinnacle of the global game in the ongoing edition. Here are five such players who are set for their last dance:

Lionel Messi (38 years): The Argentine talisman, who will turn 39 during the World Cup, is no longer shouldering the burden of attaining ultimate success, having achieved crowning glory in Qatar 2022.

There was a shadow of doubt whether he would make it to the record-equalling sixth tournament, but the richly gifted forward has opted to take the toughest football examination once again. Messi is steadily building up to full fitness after being sidelined with a hamstring injury, which he suffered when he was on duty for Inter Miami. His objective? Adding a feather to an already heavily decorated



Golden oldies: Messi, Ronaldo, Modric, Neuer, and Ochoa are among those who will probably be playing their last World Cup. GETTY IMAGES, AP, REUTERS & AFP

cap with a successful title defence.

Cristiano Ronaldo (41): The Portuguese legend would just not bow out of the international arena without straining every sinew to accomplish the mission. After multiple unsuccessful pursuits that left him heartbroken, Ronaldo, the only man to score in five iterations, will have another bite at the cherry.

The once-in-a-genera-

tion attacker has a genuine chance of hoisting the shimmering trophy, for his team has several game-changers who can alter the script in a jiffy.

On an individual note, Ronaldo, cognisant of his well-below-par returns in knockout fixtures, will be determined to exert more influence in such clashes. If he carries Portugal to the promised land, he will almost certainly be ‘sainted’

back home.

Luka Modric (40): The Croatian may be running the last mile in his illustrious career, but the mid-field master is still a feared opponent in his ‘area’ of strength.

That he plied his trade in one of Europe’s top-five leagues – for AC Milan in Serie A – last season despite being in the 40s shows his longevity with no compromise in quality.

After stumbling in the final hurdle in 2018 and coming third four years later, Modric will hope to turn those near-misses into a perfect finish. Croatia will have to come out in full force if it is to join the World Cup-winning community.

Manuel Neuer (40): The German custodian’s international return was something that not many anticipated, but head coach

Julian Nagelsmann has pinned his hopes on the shotstopper.

Neuer, donning the national colours for the first time since the European Championship in 2024, will be the No. 1 choice between the sticks provided he is in the best shape.

The goalkeeper’s volume of years in the sport and experience of tasting success at this level (in 2014) were too good to ig-

nore for Nagelsmann, who is two years younger to Neuer. “He does not need to settle in at this stage. He can handle pressure situations,” the chief coach said of the veteran.

Guillermo Ochoa (40): A Mexican World Cup squad without Ochoa in the mix will look incomplete, considering that he was a constant presence under the crossbar in the previous three editions.

The goalkeeper, chosen to represent the North American outfit in the tournament proper for the record-levelling sixth time, has revelled in performing at the quadrennial table.

But Ochoa has hardly garnered game time in recent years and may find himself on the bench again. He, however, is prepared to give head coach Javier Aguirre a ‘happy’ selection problem.

Star-studded line-up on the touchline

Ashwin Achal

There will be a star-studded line-up in the technical area of the 2026 FIFA World Cup as a host of popular managers will wield their magic.

While Didier Deschamps and Lionel Scaloni are seasoned national team coaches, others like Carlo Ancelotti and Mauricio Pochettino will hope to translate club success to the international arena.

Didier Deschamps (France): Only one of three men, alongside Franz Beckenbauer and Mario Zagallo, to have won the FIFA World Cup as both player and manager, Didier Deschamps brings stability and pedigree to France.

Since taking charge of a fractured squad from Laurent Blanc in 2012, Deschamps has built one of international football’s most consistent teams.

Under him, France won the 2018 World Cup, lifted the 2021 Nations League and finished runner-up at the 2022 World Cup.

Heading into the final tournament of his long reign, Deschamps will be eager to add another major trophy and sign off on a high.

Carlo Ancelotti (Brazil): Having last won the



Master tacticians: Deschamps, Ancelotti, Bielsa, Scaloni and Pochettino. AFP & REUTERS

World Cup back in 2002, Brazil has gone over two decades without the big prize.

The powerhouse needed a big personality to reclaim lost glory, and who better for the job than Carlo Ancelotti.

A five-time UEFA Champions League winner, and the only manager to capture league titles in Europe’s top five leagues, Ancelotti arrived with unmatched credentials.

In his first World Cup as a full-time international coach, the Italian – an expert man-manager – carries Brazil’s hopes of ending a prolonged wait for global supremacy.

Marcelo Bielsa (Uruguay): Known to extract the very best out of players through rigorous fitness conditioning and meticulous planning, Bielsa has his task cut out.

Bielsa’s high press, direct football will be tested as Uruguay is without two

star strikers – Luis Suarez (dropped) and Edinson Cavani (retired). Bielsa depends heavily on Real Madrid midfielder Federico Valverde and Al Hilal striker Darwin Nunez to buy in to his system.

Bielsa enters the mega event after a roller coaster three-year tenure, wherein Uruguay defeated giants Brazil and Argentina en route to a third-place finish at the 2024 Copa America, before going on a poor run, which included a 1-5 defeat to the USA last year.

Lionel Scaloni (Argentina):

When Lionel Scaloni was appointed Argentina manager in 2018, many questioned his credentials.

Having served as an assistant during Argentina’s disappointing 2018 World Cup campaign, he was viewed as an unlikely choice to lead one of football’s giants.

Eight years later, Scaloni has silenced every critic. Calm and understated on

the touchline, he guided Argentina to the 2021 Copa America, the 2022 World Cup and the 2024 Copa America titles.

His biggest challenge at the 2026 tournament will be balancing sentiment with pragmatism as the team enters a new era.

While Lionel Messi remains Argentina’s iconic figure, Scaloni must ensure the supporting cast is ready to carry the load.

Mauricio Pochettino (United States):

Mauricio Pochettino arrives at the World Cup carrying the expectations of a nation eager for a breakthrough on home soil.

The Argentine took charge of a United States side that has shown promise but has yet to establish itself among football’s elite.

After earning acclaim during his spell at Tottenham Hotspur, Pochettino embarked on his first international assignment with a reputation for developing young talent and building cohesive teams.

Results have been mixed against top opposition, and scrutiny has intensified. With the United States serving as a co-host, reaching the knockout stage will be considered the minimum requirement for success.

Sankar Narayanan E.H.

FIFA World Cups are as much about shared memory as they are about football.

They are, at the same time, grand and intimate – a collective realisation that we are about to turn the page to a brand-new chapter in our global family album.

While billions build memories watching the action unfold, a select few will craft theirs directly on the pitch. The ultimate intersection of football and family belongs to seven sets of brothers playing in the 2026 showpiece. While some households have the happy headache of splitting their allegiances as the siblings represent different badges, others have a straightforward and aligned legacy waiting to be forged under one flag.

Here are the brothers taking the field in the ongoing iteration of the World Cup:

Nico Williams (Spain) and Inaki Williams (Ghana): Though both ply their trade for Athletic Bilbao in LaLiga, the 23-year-old Nico decided to represent Spain, whereas the 31-year-old Inaki went with the country of his parents’ birth: Ghana. The Williams family must have got a



Sibling rivalry: Desire and Guela will play for different nations. AFP

hang of divided loyalties, for this is Nico and Inaki’s second rodeo at the quadrennial event.

Desire Doue (France) and Guela Doue (Ivory Coast): The latest battle between the Doue siblings saw Guela claim the bragging rights by scoring the equaliser against France. Although his younger brother, the 21-year-old Paris Saint-Germain playmaker, was an unused substitute, Desire set aside France’s 1-2 loss to share a warm embrace with Guela – a picture of brotherly love after the friendly encounter.

Lucas Hernandez and Theo Hernandez (France): The presence of these Marseille-born brothers makes the French defence whole. While 28-year-old Theo is with Al-Hilal in Saudi Arabia, the elder sibling plays his club

football closer to home with PSG. Their family agenda will be banishing the ghosts of finishing runner-up in Qatar by going the distance in the Americas.

Harry Souttar (Australia) and John Souttar (Scotland): Leicester City’s Harry and Rangers FC’s John, both defenders by profession, punched their tickets through different nations. While 27-year-old Harry opted to represent the country of his mother’s birth, his 29-year-old brother stayed true to his Scottish roots.

Juninho Bacuna and Leandro Bacuna (Curaçao): The Bacuna brothers, both born in the Dutch town of Groningen, will be navigating football’s biggest tournament representing the smallest nation to ever qualify for the World Cup. The 34-year-

old Leandro has racked up 70 caps in over 10 years for Curaçao, with 28-year-old Juninho, a midfielder, amassing 49 senior international appearances.

Deroy Duarte and Laros Duarte (Cape Verde): Born in Rotterdam, the Netherlands, Deroy and Laros will be the toast of Cape Verde when the nation makes its debut. Tasked with anchoring the midfield, Deroy, the younger of the two, and Laros likely perfected their partnership during the impromptu strategy sessions at the family dining table.

Brian Brobbey (Netherlands) and Derrick Luckassen (Ghana): There will be no half-measures when these half-brothers walk out to represent the Oranje and the Black Stars, respectively. While Sunderland’s Brobbey earns his stripes as a striker, 30-year-old Luckassen provides defensive steel for Ghana.

Only one of Quinten Timber and Jurrien Timber will be turning out for the Netherlands as the identical twins got separated when Jurrien was ruled out due to an injury. The onus now falls on Quinten to create everlasting memories playing mesmerising football for his country and family.

INBRIEF



Bangladesh wins maiden ODI series against Australia

Towhid Hridoy hit an unbeaten 40 as Bangladesh won the second One-Day International by five wickets on Thursday to seal its first-ever series win against Australia in the 50-over format. Chasing a DLS revised victory target of 192 in 41 overs in a rain-hit match, Bangladesh eased home to take an unassailable 2-0 lead.

The scores: Australia 187/8 in 42 overs (Marnus Labuschagne 55 n.o., Xavier Bartlett 52, Taskin Ahmed 3/33, Mustafizur Rahman 3/27) lost to Bangladesh 195/5 in 35 overs (Soumya Sarkar 42, Najmul Hossain Shanto 42, Towhid Hridoy 40 n.o.). **Target:** 192 in 41 overs; Bangladesh won by DLS method.

2027 ODI World Cup from Oct. 4 to Nov. 21: report

The 2027 ICC ODI World Cup is provisionally scheduled to be held from October 4 to November 21, across South Africa, Zimbabwe, and Namibia, according to *ESPNCricinfo*. The dates were agreed upon during the ICC board meeting in Ahmedabad in May, with final confirmation expected at the ICC Annual General Meeting in Edinburgh in July. As per the report, South Africa is likely to host the majority of matches, with at least 41 out of 54 games taking place across eight venues. Zimbabwe is expected to stage between eight and 10 games across three venues, including Victoria Falls, Harare Sports Club, and Queens in Bulawayo. Namibia will host three fixtures.

Yashbardhan to lead India under-19 in Sri Lanka

Yashbardhan Singh Chauhan was named skipper of the India men's u-19 squads for the tour of Sri Lanka in July.

The squads: One-dayers: Yashbardhan Singh Chauhan (Capt.), Lakshya Raichandani (Vice-capt.), Sagar Virk, V.K. Vineeth, Arjun Rajput, Kushagra Ojha, Rajat Baghel (wk), Anvay Dravid (wk), Anmoljeet Singh, Vutkuri Yashveer Goud, Rohit Anil Yadav, V. Shavin, Kavya Paresh Patel, Mohit Ulva, and Ishan Sood. **The dates:** July 4, 6 and 9, all at Hambantota. **Multi-day:** Yashbardhan Singh Chauhan (Capt.), Lakshya Raichandani (Vice-capt.), Sagar Virk, Kush Patel, Manal Chauhan, Kushagra Ojha, Manav Krishna (wk), Aryan Sandesh Sakpal (wk), J. Hemchudeshan, B.K. Kishore, Rohit Anil Yadav, Kavya Paresh Patel, Priyanshu Singh, Pranav Raghavendra, and Venkata Chigurupati. **The schedule:** July 13 to 16, Galle; July 20 to 23, Colombo.

Bhavika to helm India u-19 women against Sri Lanka

Bhavika Ahire will lead the India women's under-19 squads in the home series against Sri Lanka. It will figure in three T20s and three one-dayers.

The squads: T20s: Bhavika Ahire (Capt. & wk), Mahak Narwase (Vice-capt.), Ira Jadhav, Tanishka Sharma, Ishwari Awasare, Avni Chawda, Mahto Nidhi, Purva Siwach, Kumari Palak, Kashvi Kandikuppa, Maniar Maitri, Gouri Goyal, Janvi Vikar, Anaadi Tagde, and K. Deeksha (wk). **The schedule:** June 22, 24 and 27, all in Chennai. **One-dayers:** Bhavika Ahire (Capt. & wk), Mahak Narwase (Vice-capt.), Ira Jadhav, Deeya Yadav, Ishwari Awasare, V. Pratiksha, Mahto Nidhi, Purva Siwach, Kumari Palak, Kashvi Kandikuppa, Vidhi Parmar, Gouri Goyal, Janvi Vikar, Anaadi Tagde, and K. Deeksha (wk). **The dates:** June 30, July 3 and 6, all at Puducherry.



Knicks stage epic comeback, move one win from NBA title

New York Knicks staged the biggest comeback in NBA Finals history as it erased a 29-point deficit to edge San Antonio Spurs 107-106 and move within one win of the title. OG Anunoby's tip-in basket with 1.2 seconds left sealed the thrilling win to give the Knicks a 3-1 stranglehold on the best-of-seven championship series, which shifts back to San Antonio for game five on Saturday.

LIVE TELECAST

Football: World Cup, Unite8 Sports 1, 2 & Z5 App, 7.30 a.m. 12.30 a.m. & 6.30 a.m. (Saturday)

Women's T20 World Cup: Star Sports 1 & JioHotstar, 11 p.m.

FIFA WORLD CUP

Reuters
LOS ANGELES

The United States will be under pressure to launch its World Cup campaign with a victory when it hosts underdog Paraguay on Friday.

The US, at 17th, is the highest-ranked team in Group D, while Paraguay is 41st among the tournament's 48 teams and the lowest-ranked side in a group which also includes Australia and Turkey.

The US is on a three-match winning streak against the South Americans. The home side will look to shake off the nerves by scoring early with a formidable attack featuring Weston McKennie, Christian Pulisic and Folarin Balogun.

Defence is its weakness and inexperienced goalkeeper Matt Freese may have to work hard.

Paraguay had to come through the demanding CONMEBOL qualifying section, finishing last of the six automatic qualifiers in South America.



Key men: Home team's star Pulisic and Paraguay midfielder Almiron will have a big role to play in their opening encounter. AFP

Paraguay is in many ways the opposite of the US, with a physical backline that will try to slow the US attack but an offence that struggles to score, notching 14 goals in 18 games during qualifying.

Paraguay will also be without its main forward Julio Enciso, who will miss the opener with a thigh injury.

Paraguay will look to midfielder Diego Gomez to create chances and unleash dangerous shots

from distance.

Canada, also a co-host, will also carry immense pressure into its opener when it faces Bosnia and Herzegovina with both teams seeking a first-ever knockout stage berth.

Canada's quest for respectability on the global stage has been nothing short of painful, and six defeats from six matches across the 1986 and 2022 tournaments tell the story.

But coach Jesse Marsch's revolution has in-

jected fresh belief into a program that, less than two months after he took over in May 2024, advanced to the semifinals in its Copa America debut before being sent home by reigning World Cup champion Argentina.

Marsch, however, has hit an early snag here with a mounting injury list.

Captain Alphonso Davies, who scored Canada's first-ever goal at a World Cup, will watch the Group B opener from the side-

Dhiraj and Kumkum duo in mixed team recurve final

Sports Bureau

The Indian recurve mixed team pair of B. Dhiraj and Kumkum Mohod booked a berth in the final to ensure a medal for the country at the Archery World Cup Stage-3 in Antalya on Thursday.

Olympian Dhiraj and rookie Kumkum will take on Korea's Olympic medalist Kim Je Deok and former World youth champion Oh Yejin in the title clash.

The results: Team: **Elimination: Recurve: Men:** India (B. Dhiraj, Neeraj Chauhan, Yashdeep Bhoge) got a bye (first round), lost to USA 5-4 (shoot-off: 28-28", shot closer to centre) (second round). **Women:** India (Kumkum Mohod, Kirti, Ankita Bhakat) got a bye (first round), bt Netherlands 6-0 (second round), lost to Turkiye 1-5 (quarterfinal). **Mixed:** India (Kumkum Mohod, B. Dhiraj) got a bye (first round), bt Denmark 6-0 (second round), bt USA 6-2 (quarterfinal), bt Germany 6-2 (semifinal). **Compound: Mixed:** India (Sahil Jadhav, V. Jyothi Surekha) got a bye (first round), bt Italy 157-156 (second round), lost to USA 154-156 (quarterfinal).

NRAI names 30-member squad

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Manu Bhaker will compete in two events – 10m air pistol and 25m pistol – at the upcoming Asian Games while Anish Bhanwala will be the lone Indian representative in the men's 25m rapid-fire pistol event as the National Rifle Association of India on Thursday announced a 30-member shooting squad.

Besides Manu, the other shooters selected for two events are Vidarsa K. Vinod (women's 10m air rifle and 50m rifle 3 positions), former world champion Rudrankksh Patil (men's 10m air rifle and 50m rifle 3 positions), and Esha Singh (women's 10m air pistol and 25m pistol).

Asian Games squash trials to be held from today

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

The selection trials to pick the Indian men's and women's teams for the forthcoming Asian Games will be held at the ISTA Academy, Nehru Park, here from June 12 to 15. India will send a four-member playing contingent in each category for the Games to be held in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan in September-October.

Those who will be seen in action include Ramit Tandon, Velavan Senthil Kumar, Yash Fadte, Om Semwal, Aryan Pratap Singh and Suraj Chand

among men and Joshna Chinappa, Tanvi Khanna, Rathika Seelan, Sanya Vats, Shameena Riaz, Akansha Salunkhe, Pooja Arthi, Unnati Tripathi and Nirupama Dubey among women.

The six men have been divided into two groups while the nine women have been divided in two groups of five and four. The winner in each pool will make the cut.

Abhay Singh (World rank 24), Veer Chotrani (38) and Anahat Singh (20) have already made it to the team based on their world rankings and hence will not take part in the trials.

Sindhu, Tanvi enter quarters

BADMINTON

Press Trust of India
SYDNEY

P.V. Sindhu and teenager Tanvi Sharma entered the women's singles quarterfinals with straight-game wins at the Australian Open Super 500 badminton tournament here on Thursday.

Third seed Sindhu prevailed over compatriot Isharani Baruah 22-20, 21-12.

In another all-Indian contest, 17-year-old Tanvi, who stunned fifth seed and world No. 11 Chiu Pin-Chian of Taiwan on Wednesday, beat Malvika Bansod 21-13, 21-15.

The Indian men's doubles pair of Hariharan Am-sakarunan and M.R. Arjun



Moving up: Sindhu prevailed over compatriot Isharani. X@BAI_MEDIA

progressed to the quarterfinals with a 21-17, 21-7 win over Australian combination of Michael Owen and Dylan Soedjasa.

However, the Indian mixed doubles pair of Dhruv Rawat and K. Maneesha exited after losing 19-21, 18-21 to Japan's Akira Koga and Natsu Saito in the second round.

The results (second round): Women: P.V. Sindhu bt Isharani Baruah 22-20, 21-12; Tanvi Sharma bt Malvika Bansod 21-13, 21-15; Pornpawee Chochuwong bt Tanya Hemanth 21-12, 21-15.

Men: Doubles: Hariharan Amsakarunan & M.R. Arjun bt Michael Owen & Dylan Soedjasa 21-17, 21-7.

Mixed doubles: Akira Koga & Natsu Saito bt Dhruv Rawat & K. Maneesha 21-19, 21-18.

Arjun, Niemann to feature in Chennai Grand Masters



Niemann. FILE PHOTO



Arjun. FILE PHOTO

CHESS

C. Shyam Sundar
CHENNAI

Indian Grandmaster Arjun Erigaisi joins American GM Hans Niemann in a high-quality field that also includes the World champion D. Gukesh in the Quantbox Chennai Grand Masters chess tournament to be held here from July 16 to 22.

According to the organisers, Uzbekistan GM No-dirbek Abdusattorov will also be in the fray along with M. Pranesh, the winner of the Challengers event last year.

Arjun, the top-ranked

Indians as of FIDE's June rankings, will hope to put his best foot forward in a strong field after a below-par performance in the previous edition.

The tournament will only feature the Masters section this year as against the two categories in the 2025 edition.

Gukesh, who is gearing up for the defence of his World title, will be keen to use the event to fine-tune his preparations for the big match against Uzbek Javokhir Sindarov.

The rest of the line-up will be announced by next week, Grandmaster Sri-nath Narayanan, who is part of the organising team, told *The Hindu*.

Australia's waning aura gives others a genuine chance

Defending champion New Zealand, India, England and South Africa have the resources to stop the Molineux-led side; Windies can't be taken lightly; the host faces Sri Lanka in the inaugural match

ICC T20 WORLD CUP

P.K. Ajith Kumar

Sport's charm lies in unpredictability. That is a universal truth. Even for the Australian women's cricket team.

It wasn't quite so, until a couple of years ago. For a long time in women's cricket, ahead of an ICC World Cup, the big question would be who Australia would play in the final. If not who Australia would beat in the final.

The Aussie women were that good. It was a gathering of some of the game's all-time greats. The Aussie women are still good. They start as most people's favourites at the Women's T20 World Cup, which gets underway in Birmingham on Friday, with England taking on Sri Lanka.

But, the current Australian side, the most rounded among all the 12, doesn't have that aura of invincibility, which was the case when Meg Lanning led one of the best teams of all time in sport, not just cricket. There are at least four teams in contention for the title.

This promises to be not just bigger than the previous nine World Cups. It could also be the most watched one as well (more than two million viewed ICC's streaming of the warm-up match between England and India).



In for a ride: The teams' primary objective will be to earn a ticket to the knockouts. ICC

Today's match



England vs Sri Lanka

Birmingham, 11 PM. IST

HEAD-TO-HEAD

Played: 12

England 10 Sri Lanka 2

LIVE ON STAR SPORTS 1 & JIOTHTAR

This is also the most open World Cup in history. England, India, South Africa and New Zealand ensure as much. Any one of them could lift that ICC trophy at Lord's on July 5.

It is not that Australia is in decline. Just look at Alyssa Healy's replacement Georgia Voll. Or other youngsters like Annabel Sutherland and Phoebe Litchfield.

Australia is no longer the undisputed superpow-

er because others have become stronger. New Zealand is the defending champion.

India won the ODI World Cup at home last November, finally ending the agonising wait for a global title. South Africa contested the final of the last three ICC World titles, without winning any (so what is new, you might ask).

Of the five title contenders, one will bow out after the group stage. Australia, India and South Africa are all in Group A.

In Group B, England -- which should be desperate to regain the trophy it won at home in the first edition in 2009 - and New Zealand may have it easier, though the West Indies cannot be taken lightly; a team that has Hayley Matthews and Deandra Dottin can spring surprises.

Other stars ready to

shine bright this England summer include India's Smriti Mandhana, Harmanpreet Kaur and Jemimah Rodrigues; Australia's Ellyse Perry, Ashleigh Gardner and Beth Mooney; South Africa's Laura Wolvaardt and Shabnim Ismail; England's Nat Sciver-Brunt and Lauren Bell; and New Zealand's Sophie Devine and Amelia Kerr.

Devine is part of the Kiwi triumvirate - alongside Suzie Bates and Lea Tahuhu - who will end their international careers with this tournament. They represent a generation of female cricketers that had to depend on proper jobs to make a living. Like all but one of the present Netherlands team.

The Dutch will try to make a point, against the big teams. As will Scotland and Ireland, in familiar conditions.

Golden opportunity for Washington and Harsh to make a big impact

AFGHANISTAN IN INDIA

S. Dipak Ragav
DHARAMSHALA

World Cup preparations are a long-drawn process, chiselled and fine-tuned in bilateral contests. It is in these games that the team management can try out players in the heat of battle and figure out the combination.

Though there are more than 15 months to go until the 2027 ICC ODI World Cup (co-hosted by South Africa, Namibia, and Zimbabwe), India has already begun its preparations.

The Men in Blue played three one-dayers earlier in January against New Zealand. They have 17 more before the end of the year, starting with a three-match duel against Afghanistan, which begins here at the HPCA Stadium on Saturday.

This series will be crucial in auditioning candidates for spots in the middle-and-lower-order. One slot which has seen some churn in the last three ODI series has been the spin-bowling all-rounder.

After using both Axar Patel and Ravindra Jadeja in the XI during the victorious 2025 Champions Trophy campaign, India has alternated between the two in the subsequent series. Considering the conditions in South Africa won't be conducive to having two tweakers, it made sense.

While Axar got a go in Australia, Jadeja was brought back for the home assignments against South Africa and New Zealand.

However, for the series against the Afghans, neither left-armers finds a place in the squad, with the selectors handing Vidarbha's Harsh Dubey a maiden call-up.



Harsh. X@BCCI

In the mix is also Washington Sundar, who has played in six of the last nine ODIs and is looking to establish his foothold in the line-up.

These calls now raise questions about Jadeja's long-term prospects. The Saurashtra player is one of

the fittest cricketers, but will be almost 39 when the quadrennial event begins, and hasn't had the greatest of runs with the bat in recent outings.

At a time when neither Virat Kohli nor Rohit Sharma is guaranteed to feature in the World Cup, Jadeja's future in this format, too, is at a crossroads.

If age and form are factors for Jadeja, Axar's case is more curious. The Gujarat all-rounder made vital contributions in the Champions Trophy and had a decent showing with the bat in Australia, but hasn't been picked since then.

This spot is vital, considering all four contenders provide a much-needed left-handed variety to an otherwise right-hand-heavy batting line-up.

For now, Washington and Harsh will be acutely aware that they have a golden chance to make a big impact.

Afghanistan-A ekes out four-run win over India-A in a rain-affected match

Press Trust of India
DAMBULLA

Afghanistan-A caused a major upset by eking out a four-run win over star-studded India-A via the Duckworth-Lewis-Stern (DLS) method in a rain-marred tri-series match here on Thursday.

Batting first, India-A posted a daunting 349 for nine in a 49-over innings,

with Prabhsimran Singh leading the charge with a blazing 84 off 69 balls, supported by half-centuries from captain Tilak Varma (66) and Ruturaj Gaikwad (66). Due to persistent rain intervals, Afghanistan-A's target was revised to 294 runs from 38 overs.

Following an explosive start by captain Imran (75 not out off 70 balls) and Hassan Eisakhil (34 off 29

balls), Afghanistan kept themselves in the hunt. Bahir Shah (51 off 52 balls), then, joined Imran and the duo took them to 177 for two in 25.5 overs when another spell of rain stopped play.

At that stage of the game, Afghanistan was found to be four runs ahead of the par score.

Earlier, skipper Tilak, vice-captain Ruturaj and

opener Prabhsimran made well-timed fifties as India-A posted a massive total.

The scores: India-A 349/9 in 49 overs (Prabhsimran Singh 84, Ruturaj Gaikwad 66, Tilak Varma 66, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi 44; Abdollah Ahmadzai 5/68) lost to Afghanistan-A 177/2 in 25.5 overs (Imran 75 n.o. Bahir Shah 51 n.o.). *Afghanistan won by four runs via DLS method.*

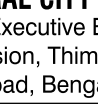
Toss: Afghanistan-A.

Player-of-the-Match: Imran.

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Registration opens for Post Graduate (PG) Programmes
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IMPORTANT DETAILS

	Link
PG	For CUET candidates: https://cuapcuetsamarth.edu.in/pg For Non-CUET candidates: https://forms.gle/8S5p11TTvmpyXnX6 Last Date for Registration: 26.06.2026
UG / Diploma / PG Diploma :	Will notify shortly on the university website: www.cuap.ac.in

For More information:
Ph: 9491490032 Web: <https://cuap.ac.in/> Email: officeofadmissions@cuap.ac.in
Sd/- Registrar

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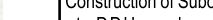
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**BENGALURU CENTRAL CITY CORPORATION**
Office of the Executive Engineer
Shivaji Nagar Division, Thimmaiah Road,
Queens Road, Bengaluru.

No: EE/SJN/KPPP/14/2026-27 Date: 11.06.2026

Invitation for Short Term Tender
(Two Cover System) (Through GOK KPPP only)
website: <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>

The Executive Engineer (Shivaji Nagar Division), BCCC, Bengaluru invites tenders from eligible Contractors registered in CPWD/KPWD/Railways/MES/National Highway or any State Government Organisations for the construction of work detailed in the table below.

Sl. No.	Name of the Work
1.	Comprehensive Development of Sri Someshwara Temple approach Roads & Drains and Surrounding area in Ward No.121, (New Ward No.08),Ulsoor.
	Amount put to Tender (₹ in Lakhs): Rs 247.48, EMD in ₹): 24,75,000/-.

Calendar of Events: (1) Pre bid meeting will be held on **17.06.2026 at 3:00 p.m.** (2) Last Date for uploading the Filled Tender documents is on **19.06.2026 up to 4:00 p.m.** (3) Date of Technical bid opening of Tenders is on **20.06.2026 at 4:30 p.m.** (4) Date of Financial bid opening of tenders is after Technical bids approved.

Sd/- Executive Engineer, Shivaji Nagar Division, BCCC.

**Government of Karnataka**
DEPARTMENT OF MINES & GEOLOGY
Office of the Director, No. 49, Khanija Bhavan, South Block,
Race Course Road, Bengaluru-560 001 Phone No:22384134/35

No. DMG-17012/26/2025/2026-27 Dated: 06.06.2026

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

The Department of Mines and Geology is calling tender for auction of seized generated iron ore fines under respective notification through MSTC.

Eligibility conditions, terms and conditions, date and time for participating in the electronic auction are provided in the Tender Document. Separate Lot wise auction notifications are published in MSTC portal. Tender Documents, notifications, updates and other details for the e-auction process of respective lots shall be available in electronic form only at the website of MSTC Ltd. <https://www.mstcecommerce.com/auctionhome/aucsearch/search.jsp>

The auction of old stock for each lot is "AS IS WHERE IS AND NO COMPLAINT BASIS". The interested bidders shall ascertain the quantity and quality of the Iron/Manganese ore before participation. The Department is not responsible for any dispute arising after confirmation of the bid. Interested bidders may visit the MSTC Ltd website.

Sd/- Director, Department of Mines & Geology

DIPR/CP/1106/NR/2026-27

**EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY**

E-Tender Notice
e-tender Notice No. 21 of 2026-27 (Open) - Engg/DDU

On line (through e-tendering) for the following work is invited by DRM/Engg/DDU for and on behalf of the President of India, is cancels E-tender No. 03-TRD-JU-ETENDER-26-27 for the following work* TRD work in connection with provision of Interlocking of 08 Nos. of manned LC gates i.e. LC-143, 147A, 147, 137 in MTD-JU section, LC-25, 18, 16 in LN-MJ section and LC-80 in RTGH-DNA section over JU Division to be Opened on 12.06.2026 due to indispensable reasons. For detailed information, visit <https://www.ireps.gov.in>

1. Tender No.27-DDU-DEN-HQ-26-27, Name of the work with its location : Construction of Subordinate Rest House at DDU under ADEN/HQ/DDU. **Advertised Value: ₹ 21172410.89, Earnest Money : ₹ 423500.00, Closing Date & time for submission of e-tender : 30.06.2026, Up-to 12:00 hrs., Website particulars of e-tendering: www.ireps.gov.in**

Divisional Railway Manager, Pt. Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Division
PR/0379/DDU/ENGG/T/26-27/32

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY
OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE
No.: EL/TRD/JUP/NIT/26-27/04

Sr. DEE/TRD/GSU/JUP, acting for and on behalf of The President of India invites E-Tenders for following works. Manual offers are not allowed against this tender, and any such manual offer received shall be ignored. **NIT No. GSU-EL-TRD-JP-2026-27-01R, Name of work:** OHE work in c/w proposed PF raising (PF-1, 2) of HDA, DHND, KKKU, DNK, BDKY station & PF extension (PF-1, 2) at KKKU station in JP-FL Section, PF raising (PF-1, 2) of BAI, BSKO, KNDL station & PF raising (PF-2) of PKBS station of Jaipur Division. **NIT cost (Rs.): 93,44,839.11, Bid Security (Rs.): 1,86,800.00, Tender opening date: 03.07.2026; NIT No. EL-TRD-JP-2026-27-01R, Name of work:** OHE & PSI work in connection with proposed extension of L-1 as common long loop at KUTY yard in BKL-JP Section of Jaipur Division. **NIT cost (Rs.): 85,40,074.45, Bid Security (Rs.): 1,70,800.00, Tender opening date: 03.07.2026; Note: Date & time of closing e-tenders: On tender opening date Up to 15.00 hrs, Date & time of opening e-tenders: On tender opening date after 15.00 hrs, Complete details of tender can be seen on website: <https://www.ireps.gov.in>**

848-PH/26

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NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY
CANCELLATION OF E-TENDER NOTICE

DRM/TRD, North Western Railway, Jodhpur for & on behalf of the president of India, is cancels E-tender No. 03-TRD-JU-ETENDER-26-27 for the following work* TRD work in connection with provision of Interlocking of 08 Nos. of manned LC gates i.e. LC-143, 147A, 147, 137 in MTD-JU section, LC-25, 18, 16 in LN-MJ section and LC-80 in RTGH-DNA section over JU Division to be Opened on 12.06.2026 due to indispensable reasons. For detailed information, visit <https://www.ireps.gov.in>

851-PH/26

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Raj.Samwad/C/26/4615 RVUN/PR-4408 Addl. Chief Engineer (O&M)

Sl. No	Online Tender no with qty/ Document Cost	Sale Period	Pre bid	Submission	Opening
1	E1545/TMSNH/MTNMSC/ENGG/2026, dt:11.06.2026 – Transcranial Magnetic Stimulation (1)–Rs.3,435/-	12.06.2026 to 28.06.2026	18.06.2026 11:00 AM	30.06.2026 11:00 AM	30.06.2026 12:00 Noon
2	E1546/SCOPERC/RTNMSC/ENGG/2026, dt:11.06.2026 – Arthroscopy Complete Set (5), ACL & PCL Instrument Set (5), RF Shoulder Arthroscopy Set (5) & Instrument for Hip Surgery (5)–Rs.5,725/-	12.06.2026 to 28.06.2026	18.06.2026 11:00 AM	30.06.2026 11:00 AM	30.06.2026 12:00 Noon
3	E1547/ISO/CONATINER/TNMSC/ENGG/2026, dt:11.06.2026 –40'ISO Cryogenic Tank Containers for LMO to lease or dispose (12)–Rs.5,725/-	12.06.2026 to 28.06.2026	18.06.2026 11:00 AM	30.06.2026 11:00 AM	30.06.2026 12:00 Noon
4	E1548/EYERC/TNMSC/ENGG/2026, dt:11.06.2026 – Auto Refractometer with Keratometer (13)–Rs.3,435/-	15.06.2026 to 30.06.2026	22.06.2026 11:30 AM	01.07.2026 11:00 AM	01.07.2026 12:00 Noon
5	E1549/-COT/RC/TNMSC/ENGG/2026, dt:11.06.2026 –Labour Cot with Mattress (175)–Rs.725/-	15.06.2026 to 30.06.2026	22.06.2026 11:30 AM	01.07.2026 11:00 AM	01.07.2026 12:00 Noon
6	E1550/LAUNDRY/RC/TNMSC/ENGG/2026, dt:11.06.2026 – Various Laundry Items–Rs.725/-	15.06.2026 to 30.06.2026	22.06.2026 12:00 noon	01.07.2026 11:00 AM	01.07.2026 12:00 Noon
7	E1551/BAL/DME-KP/MTNMSC/ENGG/2026, dt:11.06.2026 –Analytical Balance (1)–Rs.3,435/-	15.06.2026 to 30.06.2026	22.06.2026 12:30 PM	01.07.2026 11:00 AM	01.07.2026 12:00 Noon

For details visit www.intenders.gov.in and TNMSC website www.tnmsctn.gov.in
DIPR/ 2045 /TENDER/2026

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FACULTY RECRUITMENT : EXTENSION OF LAST DATE

In continuation to this Office Advertisement No.-1762 Dated **12.05.2026 (For the Post of Professor), No.1765 Dated 12.05.2026 (For the Post of Associate Professor) and No.1768 Dated 12.05.2026 (For the Post of Assistant Professor)**, the **closing date and time** for online submission of application form in HIMS portal is hereby extended from **11.06.2026 (11.59 PM) to 20.06.2026 (11.59 PM)**. Accordingly, the closing date of receiving the hard copy of the application along with the required documents through Speed / Registered Post is extended from **20.06.2026 (05.00 PM) to 29.06.2026 (05.00 PM)**.

All other terms and conditions mentioned in the above Advertisements remain unchanged.

No.2482 / Date. 11.06.2026 REGISTRAR
11001/124/2627 OPR-11001/11008/1/26-27/0011

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No. 8947 / TSM, Bhubaneswar, dt. 10.06.2026
TCT-TSP-FEST-0003-2023

INDICATIVE ADVERTISEMENT

APPLICATION FOR 37TH KONARK FESTIVAL
(1st to 5th December 2026)
Open Air Auditorium, Konark, Odisha, India

Tourism Department, Government of Odisha invites online applications separately from eligible Troupe/ Institute/ Organisation to perform in the Indian Classical Dance forms i.e. Odissi, Kathak, Bharatnatyam, Mohiniyattam, Kuchipudi and Sattriya for the **37th Konark Festival** scheduled to be held from **1st to 5th December 2026**.

For detailed information, interested Troupe/ Institute/ Organisation are requested to visit online application portal www.odishatourism.gov.in which shall remain open from the **12th June 2026 to 15th July 2026**.

(Biswajit Routray)
Additional Director
OIPR-37001/37001/1/26-27/0005

37001/21/2627

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Stokes — the problem child

Each time he was in the dock, the star all-rounder dug deep to come back stronger, endearing himself to England's historically unforgiving cricketing populace; the fact that Brook has been overlooked and the captaincy returned to Root, if only on a temporary basis, reiterates how shaken the mandarins at the ECB are at the latest turn of events



R. Kaushik

Ben Stokes is an extraordinary cricketer who has done extraordinary things on the cricket field. Superhuman. Out of the world. Impossibly compelling. These are some of the adjectives that have accompanied his stirring deeds, driven as much by his supreme skills and his never-say-die attitude as the bull-headed unwillingness to surrender even when the odds are stacked heavily against him.

Born in Christchurch in the Antipodes but having made the historic city of Durham in the North-East of England his home several moons back, the 35-year-old has scaled dizzying heights through sheer weight of character. With the bat, he can switch from watchful defence to a blitz of epic proportions in the blink of an eye. He is a most accomplished operator with the ball, but it's for his ability, indeed willingness, to do the dirty job that he truly stands out.

When England seek control, Stokes takes it upon himself to dry up the runs. When they try to bounce batters out, Stokes thinks little of going round the stumps and bashing the ball into the most docile of pitches ball after ball, over after over, going even eight or nine overs in a spell without losing pace, intensity, energy or direction. He is a fabulous fielder, sure of hands and athletic beyond compare. And he is a grand leader of men, always in the thick of battle. He is the quintessential all-round package, the premier all-rounder of his generation bar none, one of those players that, as they say, 'put bums on the seats'.

There has to be a streak of madness, however, in the round-the-wicket mode of operation that has become a Stokes calling card, and sometimes (maybe more than sometimes), that streak manifests itself off the field, often with a little nudge from Bacchus. Stokes' latest dalliance, in cahoots with Gus Atkinson, has heaped further misery on a system that is seen as being subservient to players, who appear to have perfected the art of bossing over their bosses.

Stunning twist

In a stunning turn of events, Stokes (and Atkinson) have been stood down from the second Test against New Zealand, starting at the Oval on Wednesday, following their run-in with a Saracens rugby player last Sunday, hours after England pulled off a comfortable win over the Kiwis at the home of English cricket. Lord's threw up a diabolical 22-yard strip that made batting a lottery, and made heroes out of workmen-like bowlers. So heavily skewed in favour of the bowlers was the pitch that match referee Andy Pycroft was compelled to rate it 'unsatisfactory' (perhaps he was a touch generous), a massive blow to the reputation of a venue that prides itself on being the very definition of prim and proper. If Lord's can be perceived as having failed to live

up to the lofty standards that have come to be associated with it, surely, we shouldn't be surprised at Stokes playing true to character, right?

Stokes has a long and disturbing history with nightclubs and other watering holes. The most visible of misadventures came in 2017 in Bristol when, after an ODI against West Indies, he was involved in a late-night altercation outside a nightclub. After a flurry of punches that might not have been out of place in a boxing ring, Stokes was arrested and charged with affray, lost his vice-captaincy, was suspended by the England and Wales Cricket Board and missed the 2017-18 Ashes tour of Australia.

After an understandably high-profile trial, he was clear of affray charges in August 2018. Stokes celebrated in style, playing a lead role in England's maiden tryst with the 50-over World Cup the following July and playing one of the most unforgettable fourth-innings knocks in Leeds to single-handedly pilot his side to a one-wicket victory against the old foe.

Long before this, he had been cautioned officially by the cops during a night out in Newcastle (2012) early in his career, which meant that he wasn't considered for international selection for a year thereafter even though he had debuted in both white-ball formats by the time. A year on, he was sent home from an England Lions tour of Australia (alongside Matt Coles) for breaching drinking and curfew rules while in 2014, he completed a hat-trick of ignominy when he fractured his hand after smashing a dressing room locker in frustration on being run out in the Caribbean, an injury severe enough to rule him out of the T20 World Cup in Bangladesh.

Each time he was in the dock, Stokes dug deep to come back stronger, endearing himself to England's historically unforgiving cricketing populace through sheer bloody-mindedness and the propensity to leave nothing behind in the dressing-room. One couldn't help but admire his resolve (so much so, that his remarkable skills were almost taken for granted) and he became larger than life in the country which he had made his home very early, eventually ascending the captaincy in 2022 after a terrible run under Joe Root that produced just a solitary Test win in the Yorkshireman's last 17 outings as captain.

In a sequence of developments that can so easily find a special mention in *Ripley's Believe It or Not*, Root, also 35 and arguably the greatest English batter of all time, is now back as Test skipper, albeit in an interim capacity, for the Oval skirmish against Tom Latham's beleaguered troops. By and in itself, that's an interesting development because Harry Brook, the white-ball captain, was Stokes' designated deputy. The fact that Brook has been overlooked and the captaincy returned to Root, if only on a temporary

basis, reiterates how shaken the mandarins at the ECB are at the latest turn of events where, we are repeatedly being told, the *only* transgression Stokes and Atkinson were guilty of was breaking team curfew rules.

The curfew was imposed this January after a litany of bad behaviour with the high-profile Brook and opener Ben Duckett in the crosshairs, the former in New Zealand on the eve of an ODI in his first series as captain and the latter during the ill-fated Ashes tour down under in the last Australian summer. England had sought to sweep the Brook episode under the carpet after he was 'clocked' by a bouncer outside a nightclub in Wellington the night before the final ODI. He was fined more than ₹36 lakh and almost lost his captaincy. A few months later, a video surfaced of Duckett purportedly drunk and unable to find his way to the team hotel in Noosa when England embarked on a pre-arranged mid-series break between the second and the third Ashes Tests despite being 0-2 down in the most furiously followed cricketing faceoff.

Ironically, alongside head coach Brendon McCullum with whom he once enjoyed a fabulous relationship rumoured to have gone pear-shaped during the disastrous Ashes campaign, Stokes was among the prime movers of the curfew imposed ahead of a white-ball tour of Sri Lanka that was to culminate in the T20 World Cup in India and Sri Lanka in February-March. For the skipper therefore to breach the rules he himself had helped put in place is poor optics, never mind if he and Atkinson, like we are being told, were not the *agent provocateurs* in the London incident of Sunday at Chelsea's Rex Rooms nightclub which left an ECB security personnel needing stitches after reportedly being struck by the Saracens' Samoan rugby player, Tootoa Auvaa.

Mixed messages

There have been mixed messages from England in the days since the incident came to light. It is been rumoured that Stokes might not just step down from the captaincy but retire entirely from the sport, which might seem like an overreaction until one is informed that there is no guarantee that he will be selected in the Test squad if he quits the leadership role because he has scored only 31 runs in his last six Test innings. Anyone who has followed the Stokes graph with only cursory interest knows well the perils of ruling him out prematurely. But clearly, England's bosses with McCullum -- himself under scrutiny for his backfiring Bazball tactics -- at the helm might feel Stokes' best days are behind him and that the responsibility of taking the team forward across formats must be entrusted to the exciting, unconventional and aggressive Brook.

The problem is that all these Brook traits, so arresting on the cricket field, have spilled over beyond the boundary.

Root's temporary elevation as skipper is the ultimate acknowledgement from the decision-making group at this troubled time, England are looking for stability and maturity and poise and measured leadership in the short term, all of which Root provides in abundance and which aren't necessarily Brook's visible USPs. It can also be construed as a message, however belated, that there will be no more tolerance of unacceptable behaviour from young men tasked with not just acquitting themselves with credit on the cricket field but who are also installed as global ambassadors of their country. Nasser Hussain and Mike Atherton, respected former captains with respected voices, are unequivocal in stating that the Rex Rooms standoff isn't a 'sackable offence'. *Per se*, they are absolutely right. After all, one can argue, they were out celebrating a Test victory -- unlike Brook in Wellington -- and that shouldn't be a crime in itself. But when the captain breaks the same rules that he had helped implement, surely, it must come with repercussions far greater than if only a 'mere' member of the side was guilty of curfew-breaking. Which is exactly why there is a more lenient view of paceman Atkinson's misdemeanour.

Stokes, it would seem, has chosen not to make decisions from a place of emotion, which is just as well because any immediate emotional call will inevitably come with regrets for a lifetime. He has a few days to consider where he stands, where is at mentally, how much gas he has left in the mental tank, confabulate with his bosses, read the room and then decide how he wants to play it. If he is seen to be sincerely remorseful, he could be back, at least as a player. If he has played his last international game, it will be a shame but then again, actions do have consequences, don't they?

THE GIST

Stokes has a long and disturbing history with nightclubs and other watering holes. The most visible of misadventures came in 2017 in Bristol when, after an ODI against West Indies, he was involved in a late-night altercation outside a nightclub

The problem is that all the Brook traits, so arresting on the cricket field, have spilled over beyond the boundary. Root's temporary elevation as skipper is the ultimate acknowledgement from the decision-making group at this troubled time, England are looking for stability and maturity

When the captain breaks the same rules that he had helped implement, surely, it must come with repercussions far greater than if only a 'mere' member of the side was guilty



Contraceptive use and the weight women carry: insights from NFHS-6

India must invest in policies that move contraceptive use from compliance to choice: this will involve ensuring no girl is married before the age of 18, investing in rural secondary education, and increasing access to reversible scientific contraception methods

Trishna Sarkar
C. Saratchand

Reproductive agency, the power to decide whether, when, and how to bear children is a vital and necessary component of women's empowerment, and yet, is often not taken into account when metrics of income, education, mobility and political representation are analysed.

India's demographic transition, as reflected in the latest round of the National Family Health Survey (NFHS-6, 2023-24), besides revealing incremental changes in health indicators, also signals a structural shift in the domain of reproductive agency. Contraception, once framed primarily as an instrument of population control, is increasingly emerging as a marker of women's reproduction agency.

History of contraceptive use

India's engagement with contraception dates back to 1952, when it became the first country to launch an official family planning programme but with women bearing a disproportionate share of the required responsibility.

The following data, drawn from the NFHS-6 (2023-24) survey of currently married women aged 15- 49 years, maps the reproductive and contraceptive landscape across urban and rural India, and against the NFHS-5 baseline:

A striking finding in the NFHS-6 data is the persistence of early marriage. Nationally, 20.1% of women aged 20-24 was married before the age of 18, with the rural figure reaching 23.3% – unchanged from NFHS-5. Among men, 15.9% aged 25-29 were married before 21. These trends are not only legal failures, they are also healthcare setbacks.

A girl married before she has had the opportunity to complete secondary education or enter the paid workforce, confronts a significantly extended reproductive window. When contraceptive access is limited, awareness of healthcare attenuated, or agency within the family is negligible, unhealthy pregnancies, unsustainably more births, and heightened maternal and child health risk are the consequences. The data bears this out: 6.7% of women aged 15-19 were already mothers or pregnant at the time of the survey rising to 7.9% in rural areas.

From a public health standpoint, early marriage is not merely a social problem, it is a reproductive health emergency with lifelong consequences. Girls married young are less likely to know their contraceptive options, less likely to be able to negotiate their use, and more likely to undergo less spaced-out pregnancies. The cumulative physiological burden of anaemia, obstetric complications and maternal mortality is concentrated precisely in this



Reproductive rights: India's engagement with contraception dates back to 1952, when it became the first country to launch an official family planning programme but with women bearing a disproportionate share of the required responsibility. FILE PHOTO

demographic. Yet policy conversations about fertility routinely overlook the role of early marital unions, seeking to unsuccessfully treat the symptom (high fertility) while ignoring the structural cause (constrained reproductive agency).

The rural-urban divide in these figures is striking. Urban women tend to marry later, complete more schooling, and are exposed to a broader suite of contraceptive options. Rural women face the inverse: earlier marital unions, relatively less agency, and a healthcare infrastructure that, as we shall see, defaults to unattainable permanent solutions rather than investing in what is relevant: public healthcare.

On sterilisation

Female sterilisation remains the dominant contraceptive method in India, accounting for 36.5% of all contraceptive use nationally and is as high as 38.1% in rural areas. Male sterilisation, by contrast, stands at a negligible 0.5%. This gargantuan skew is the consequence of policy design and gender disempowerment.

The NFHS-6 data also shows a modest decline in female sterilisation from 37.9% (NFHS-5) to 36.5%, alongside a sharp rise in traditional method use (from 10.3% to 16.4%) and a slight decline in modern reversible methods (from 56.4% to 52.7%). Read together, these trends suggest that some women are able to step back from sterilisation – but into informal, less

Female sterilisation remains the dominant contraceptive method, accounting for 36.5% of all contraceptive use nationally and is as high as 38.1% in rural areas

medically supported methods rather than towards reversible scientific methods that would authentically enhance reproductive autonomy.

Female sterilisation in India's public health system has a troubled history. The mass sterilisation camps epitomised by the Bilaspur tragedy of 2014, in which 13 women died following a single-day mass sterilisation drive are not aberrations but logical consequences of a system that treats women's reproductive capacity as a population management problem to be solved at scale, cheaply and rapidly. Tubectomies and sterilisation surgeries done in rural government hospitals can sometimes be risky – these facilities are overcrowded, staff are not always well-trained, and the focus is on performing as many procedures as possible rather than on scientific patient care. Women who go through these surgeries can get infections, complications from maladministered anaesthesia or failed procedures resulting in increased morbidity. Most women are compelled to access what they can afford, namely underfunded public healthcare. Most women undergoing such procedures

are not empowered to make an informed choice due to their being at the short end of the stick of the social reproduction and social production processes.

Towards reproductive agency

An analysis of the NFHS-6 data demonstrates that contraception in India is no longer merely about limiting births, but about enabling reproductive agency by overcoming the underlying unequal social architecture.

Three policy imperatives follow from such an analysis. First, early marriage must be addressed as a reproductive health crisis by retaining girls in school, fully implementing the Prohibition of Child Marriage Act and investing in rural secondary education for girls. Second, policy must pivot from unsustainable permanent methods of contraception toward increasing access for reversible scientific contraception through augmenting community based public healthcare. Third, the diminishing of the gender skew in contraception must become a programmatic priority of policy. Sustainable demographic transition presupposes reproductive agency of women.

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THE GIST

Contraception, once framed primarily as an instrument of population control, is increasingly emerging as a marker of women's reproduction agency

When contraceptive access is limited, awareness of healthcare attenuated, or agency within the family is negligible, unhealthy pregnancies, unsustainably more births, and heightened maternal and child health risk are the consequences

An analysis of the NFHS-6 data demonstrates that contraception in India is no longer merely about limiting births, but about enabling reproductive agency by overcoming the underlying unequal social architecture

SNIPPETS

Latest updates from the world of health

Ingredient for sunscreen



Reuters

The U.S. Food and Drug Administration on Tuesday said it added bemotrizinol to its list of permitted active ingredients, marking the first new UV (Ultraviolet) filter to be cleared for over-the-counter sunscreens since the late 1990s.

Bemotrizinol helps protect against both ultraviolet A and B rays and has low levels of absorption through the skin into the body, the U.S. Food and Drug Administration said.

Support fund to fight Ebola



Reuters

The U.S. State Department said on Wednesday it would provide an additional \$20 million to help fight the Ebola outbreak in Africa, bringing its total direct support to more than \$220 million. The money will support preparedness efforts in Burundi, Kenya, Rwanda, and South Sudan, including for national emergency operations centres, as well as surveillance, testing, border screening and infection prevention and control.

AI dolls for loneliness



Agence France-Presse

Many older South Koreans are battling loneliness. The country has low birth rates and almost half the population is 50 or older. In 2024, it recorded more than 3,920 "lonely deaths", people dying alone and remaining undiscovered for extended periods. To combat this, authorities are providing AI care devices – some designed to detect signs of lonely deaths – to seniors living alone for companionship and safety-monitoring.

Misconceptions continue to deter men from getting vasectomies, say experts

Athira Elssa Johnson

According to the findings of the sixth National Family Health Survey (NFHS-6), India's Total Fertility Rate (TFR) has remained at 2.0 children per woman, below the replacement level of 2.1. The survey also points to improved access to family planning services, with the contraceptive prevalence rate increasing from 66.7% in NFHS-5 to 69.1%. The burden of contraception, however, continues to remain shouldered largely by women.

Sterilisation, accounts for a significant chunk of contraception methods used in India. As per NFHS-6, male sterilisation (vasectomy) remains at a dismal 0.5%, barely a change from 0.3% in NFHS-5.

Experts say misconceptions surrounding vasectomy continue to discourage men from taking a more active role in family planning, placing a disproportionate share of the burden on women. A study published in the journal *BMJ Sexual & Reproductive Health* found that fears about loss of libido and physical weakness, social stigma, poor awareness and health system barriers continue to impede acceptance of vasectomy among married men in India, with uptake declining from 3.31% in the early 1990s.

Experts note that vasectomy is a simple, safe and highly effective long term contraceptive method that does not affect sexual performance or libido, contrary to these widespread myths. One of the most persistent

A study published in the journal BMJ Sexual & Reproductive Health found that fears about loss of libido and physical weakness, social stigma, poor awareness and health system barriers continue to impede acceptance of vasectomy among married men in India

misconceptions surrounding vasectomy is that it diminishes sexual function. However, there is no evidence to support these claims.

N. Ragavan, senior consultant-urologist, Apollo Hospitals, Chennai, said the belief is cultural and has no clinical basis. "Fertility should not be tied to misconceptions that equate a man's reproductive capacity with his masculinity as though fewer sperm somehow mean less manhood," he said, adding that vasectomy does not affect testosterone levels or sexual drive. The procedure merely involves blocking the sperm-carrying tube and does not interfere with blood supply to the testes or their normal function. It has nothing to do with libido or erectile function, he said.

Muthu Veeramani, director and senior consultant, urology, SIMS Hospital, Chennai, added that studies have consistently shown that vasectomy does not affect testosterone production, sexual desire or sexual performance.

Experts also sought to dispel the notion that vasectomy is a major surgery associated with serious health risks.

Vasantharaja Ramasamy, senior consultant, urology, MGM Malar Hospital, Chennai, said the procedure is usually carried out under local anaesthesia. After identifying the vas deferens (sperm duct) through palpation, a small incision is made and the tube is divided and sealed to prevent reconnection. Patients are discharged within a few hours and can resume routine activities after a couple of days, although heavy physical activity should be avoided for about a week.

Myths from social media

Doctors also rejected several myths circulating on social media, including claims that vasectomy causes obesity, cancer, infections or long-term health complications. Dr. Ragavan said there was no indication that the procedure increased the risk of obesity or cancer, and no scientific evidence to support such claims.

Despite being simpler and less invasive than female sterilisation, vasectomy continues to have low acceptance, especially in India. One major concern among men is that vasectomy is irreversible and could lead to regrets later in life. Experts emphasise that recanalisation procedures performed within three years of vasectomy have success rates exceeding 90%. Additionally, advances in microscopic surgery have improved outcomes when reversals are undertaken after proper counselling.

Greater male participation in reproductive health, doctors noted, would make reproductive healthcare more equitable. (athira.elssa@thehindu.co.in)